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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IWWkBYMYDSg
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:32:42] - Good, well that worked almost. All right, we have a pretty important day today. You know, one of the things that we've talked about, but obviously don't have a lot of initial control over is literacy. We're gonna have a full afternoon work session on literacy in the Commonwealth.

[00:33:01] All of you understand that, you know, a fairly groundbreaking bill was put through the assembly this year. And, you know, a number of the speakers will talk to that. We have on the Zoom, Dr. Carrie Wright from the Mississippi State Superintendent of Education.

[00:33:20] Welcome, I don't know if you can hear me, Dr. Wright, yes? - Yes, I can, can you hear me? - I can, I miss seeing your part of the universe. You know, my grandparents were from Edwards. I don't know if you know where that is, somewhere between Jackson and Vicksburg.

[00:33:37] So, you know, always good to have somebody from the old homeland on the call with us. - Happy to be here. - First, what we're gonna do is hear from Carrie Coiner, the Honorable Carrie Coiner in the House of Delegates representing my county of Chesterfield.

[00:33:59] Carrie and I worked together for quite some time in the county for the benefit, we hope, of the children of the county. And now Carrie has had an opportunity and has taken it to work for the betterment of all the children in the Commonwealth.

[00:34:14] And Carrie, you're on, anywhere you'd like to be. All right. Well, I'll stand up here so I can see all of you. Well, thank you so much for having me. It's an honor to be here. You know, I did serve in Chesterfield, and I'm thankful to spend eight years, Dan Gecker and I serving on Board of Supervisors and School Board, and we sat with sidebar conversations many times about if we could just fix things in the world without politics, how easy it would be.

[00:34:47] So, you know, it's been interesting going from local service to statewide service, and my goal is still to figure out how to get things done and taking some of the politics out of it. And I think this is one of those areas and bills that with the voting record of bringing everybody together and lack of any opposition, we were able to successfully do that.

[00:35:08] And I'll talk a little bit about that. I think it's important for your board to sort of know how we navigate in, because I know you've had some initiatives and things that you'd like to see done. And I think there's some lessons to be learned in how we got to really unanimous support or neutrality if folks weren't 100% confident.

[00:35:25] We didn't really have opposition in this effort. So the Virginia Literacy Act, which is what the bill is known as, really started several years ago. Actually, Dan and I were sitting in my office having a conversation about all the things that would improve outcomes for students and improve things for teachers and families.

[00:35:46] And we sort of made this on the back of a napkin list of items together. And literacy was one of those items. Professional development for teachers was one of those items. We could go on and on. But I really took that list. SOL testing, growth was one of them.

[00:36:03] I took that list and I got started last year. So last session was about growth assessments. And then I was really fortunate to work with the UVA Law School Local Government and State Public Policy Clinic and started talking to them about literacy.

[00:36:20] And the professor running that clinic was good friends with one of the professors in the School of Education and said, you know, I think we can move forward and help you, support you, tackle the early literacy this year. So we got started over the summer, and our work really started looking at our current data.

[00:36:36] I will say one of the things I realized really early on as a legislator was we have a lot of great data on literacy at our fingertips, and I believe it's being underutilized by everyone involved in public education.

[00:36:53] Our PALS office has a ton of data on what's happening with our littlest learners, and I think data also shows you where we're not collecting more data that we need like about how dollars are being used to help students who are behind in literacy when you don't know how that money is being sent and you don't see the needle moving it oftentimes will shine a flashlight on additional information we need to make better decisions moving forward so we started looking at our current data and then we started looking at best practices across the country which is how I met Dr. Carrie Wright we met via zoom we've never met in person. But we met via Zoom thanks to the Hunt Institute who helped connect us. So I

[00:37:32] called them and said, do you know her? I need to meet her. And they said yes. So that's how we got connected. But she was very helpful. I went to Superintendent Wright and really said, tell me the pitfalls you ran into when you moved forward with this legislatively. What do you wish you had done

differently? And really the lessons that she learned is how we set up our framework of our path forward. So I can't overemphasize the importance of finding other people who have done the work you want to do. And you don't have to do it just like them. Our bill is not exactly as Superintendent Wright did it, but understanding where they ran into barriers and where people had questions was very, very helpful. So what our bill does, it pulls on

[00:38:12] four levers. That's what we referred to it as to help folks understand it for early literacy. It's all based in scientifically based reading research, and so the first lever is really ensuring that our higher education institutions are preparing our future teachers in the practice of scientifically based reading research, and so that our K through 12 school systems aren't retraining folks who are coming out of school.

[00:38:39] And what we heard over and over again about teacher retention, that if they weren't prepared for the classroom and their students weren't achieving, we saw a lot more teachers leaving the profession when they were new. So one, it's going to help teachers who are in our youngest grades have the skill sets that they need to see their students achieving and growing and reading. And it's also going to save a lot of time and money for our K-12 folks on the back end not having to retrain new teachers. So that was step one. Step two was looking at our K-12 professional development and what we're providing for our K-12 principals, for

[00:39:15] our teachers, for all staff who are in our elementary schools, and ensuring that their professional development aligns with scientifically-based reading research, and that it's not a sit and get one-time professional development. We funded and provided a white paper to support the implementation of this work with reading coaches that will be provided to reading specialists throughout the state. So based on the work that Superintendent Wright did, really looked at a regional model. So you'll have your classroom teachers. You will have, thanks to our funding in the bill, reading specialists that are

[00:39:52] funded for all of our K-3 students across the state, whether you were behind in reading or not. Everybody gets the benefit in their schools of a reading specialist. And then a regional coaching model, someone who will be constantly supporting the work of those reading specialists. Our bill really envisions our reading specialists being coaches to classroom teachers is a top priority. And then second, ensuring that those reading specialists can help with interventions and helping students who are behind. So you'll notice our ratio for reading specialists isn't tied to the number of students who aren't meeting benchmarks. It's a reading

[00:40:25] specialist for all because that quality reading is important for everyone. The third part, third lever of our bill really tags onto scientifically based reading research curriculum, so that curriculum is founded in it, that our interventions that we're using are founded in it, and that our screening tools are all tied and aligned, so that's consistent. So you'll see that that was the third lever. And then the fourth one is about parents and what they are receiving. What we heard from parents was that they didn't understand where their children were behind. You know, we give

[00:41:03] parents data, and it's all these numbers, like your child has a 600, your child's at a 28, your child's at a 92, and those numbers mean nothing to the average parent. So we included a lever in the bill to develop a parent resource bank so that when that screener tool comes back and teachers can convey and learn how to convey the data to parents, that there is a statewide parent resource Bank that they can go to and see exactly what they can do at home to help their student if they're behind in any areas in that early literacy.

[00:41:37] So we did put in a budget amendment and made it through the House and the Senate versions, and we have full faith and confidence that it's going to stay there. We would love to see our reading specialist ratio a little extra money to go through fourth and fifth grade.

[00:41:53] That would make us even happier. We did provide flexibility where those reading specialists, even though the ratio is tied to your K through three, that reading specialist can still serve fourth and fifth graders, but the ratio is tied to how many kindergarten through third graders you have in a building.

[00:42:09] Our desire would be that we keep that same ratio but expand it to include all your K through fifth graders in a building in future years. We spent a lot of time working on questions and answers, so anybody throughout this journey of the bill who sent us a question you received a written answer from us we can provide you all with this but the virginia state literary literacy association probably had the most questions throughout our journey and we answered all of those but we gave the responses to all stakeholders so anyone who was part of our email list received those and we continued to develop

[00:42:44] it so it's a great it was a great tool in this journey and to not lose folks along the way in regards to things they may not understand. I will say, you know, we intentionally chose not to use the term science of reading in our legislation because like other terms that become popular and get used, they can oftentimes be confused or not mean what we intend them to mean. So we're very specific on definitions within our legislation, ensuring that we had consistency throughout the code um part of this bill was also cleanup so what you'll notice um we took a lot of things out of

[00:43:21] the state code so part of it was deleting um programs like reading recovery and others other references to types of literacy programs or literacy interventions that are not best practice anymore but they were housed within our code so it was also a little bit of a cleanup bill so that's what our bill did you'll see the funding is for reading specialists in all of our schools and you'll also see money for video we a support position to support early literacy you'll see new curriculum grant money in their materials for parents you'll see money for

[00:43:57] micro credentialing so that we ensure that if we do have a pipeline issue for reading specialists in all our schools that that can be developed and we can get that pipeline going you'll see that there's funding so that the pals program can house the literacy coaches and and help run that and you'll see training materials and teacher training all within the money that was put into the budget amendment so that i'm happy to answer questions but that's what our bill did and we're going to keep working so our goal is to tackle fourth through eighth grade in the next session because there's still work to be done so we just did our earliest

[00:44:35] learners this past year great well thank you so much carrie for being with us are there any questions dr duran not necessarily a question just thank you this is so exciting to hear this and i'm really really pleased that as a school system leader currently not just on the state board that we have the focus now in the code as well as the funding as well as the leadership from the general assembly all the way down to show how important literacy is i can't thank you enough for your leadership and standing strong and getting it to be unanimous because i know having these

[00:45:11] conversations at the local level initially many years ago it wasn't always unanimous and there's a lot of misunderstanding i believe in the terminology so i'm really thankful that you stayed a little bit away from the terminology to help people understand what the real issue is and getting back to the data so i look forward to just how this flows out and i'm really glad on the state board we're focusing on it today

and what we can do as leaders across the commonwealth to make it happen i do think it's critical and i was happy to hear you in the bill that the leaders are also provided professional development and learning not about what is actually happening in the classroom per se but how to lead this work those are two different issues about how to lead this work and make sure the teachers have the resources needed so thank you so much i'm just so pleased

[00:45:50] and i've been following this all along and i'm just glad to have the opportunity to thank you in person you're welcome anybody else yes well first of all just yes thank you delegate corner for your incredible leadership on this and finding common ground in a time when that's not always easy to do and it shouldn't be hard to do because we're all here to advance our students success and you've really zeroed in on such an important area and done terrific leadership on it i actually have two questions and i'll pose them both and the first is am i right that the success of our

[00:46:29] literacy efforts are intimately tied to our early childhood efforts more broadly and can you comment on how are we doing on on early childhood more broadly and what's your sense of support for continuing the early childhood initiatives that we're in the midst of going forward what's the sense of support for that in the legislature that's the first question and then the second is you know have we done any or is this yet to come work assessment of the sort of what's working and what's not and in particular i'm always interested in do we have found models are there jurisdictions

[00:47:07] districts that are doing this right already and getting results despite obstacles, you know, with barrier, you know, districts with barriers that are overcoming those barriers, and likewise in the ed prep programs. Do we have some that are doing it right that we can all learn from, or what else have we done to assess what's working and what's not already as we start going forward? Sure. So, yes, you know, I will say when we also started doing our research, not just from other states, but within Virginia, I would say within VDOE, your special education area within VDOE was doing a great job of moving in this direction of scientifically-based

[00:47:46] reading research, but we don't want it to be something that's only for students with disabilities. This is a best practice for all children and all students. So we know that there is success that has been shown in Virginia and those areas, but it really is best for all. I would also say that from the data perspective, where we saw the lack of data you already had available as a state not being used, that early childhood being a new up-and-coming thing in Virginia, they are probably showing the most best practice of collecting of data and being

[00:48:22] able to use that of anyone else right now. And I think sometimes we fail to share our data because it doesn't look good right but we we only get better if we talk about well what's going on and within every data set there's some stars right there's some folks that are figuring it out and unless we're willing to show all of that data and pick out those stars and go okay well why is it working there but not here we can't help everybody in the commonwealth so you know one of the things our bill did um we required every school division to provide you all with a literacy

[00:48:59] plan every two years as part of this bill and the reason for that is as a state we're sending a ton of money to school districts to help catch up our learners who are behind in literacy and yet we weren't seeing the needle move for the vast majority of them you're going to have at your fingertips now going forward as part of those two-year plans the data that you can see for the division that plan will tell you

where they spent their money to help their struggling readers and then you'll be be able to see with the following year's data whether that worked or not.

[00:49:30] And when you're able to take all those plans across the state and see real-time data, see the resources that were being used, you'll be able to more quickly, especially with these regional literacy coaches, help share best practices and what's working and what's not across the Commonwealth and help provide some better direction.

[00:49:48] So I'm really hopeful that within our state you'll see those. So Virginia Beach, that's a great example of one locality that was sort of moving in this direction already. They're just at the beginning, so you're not going to see any data points yet. But when we met with them, one of their struggles was, well, we're doing this, but because teachers come and go from different jurisdictions and students come and go in and out of our city, it's hard to build consistently when everyone around us isn't, aren't training their teachers the same way and their kids aren't receiving the same foundations of literacy.

[00:50:20] And so that consistency, I know we talk, and I'm from a school board, so I know we want local control of stuff, but I do think we need to have some important conversations about where are consistencies that benefit all of us, that we can develop statewide so that we can provide resources regardless of how much money your locality has, and so that teachers can move in and out of jurisdictions as well as students and still feel that same consistency.

[00:50:46] So I think that's part of what made us successful. We were able to tackle that local control issue They say you can still choose your curriculum We just want to make sure whatever is being chosen across the state that the alignment is consistent And so that was really helpful. Gary. Thank you so much for taking the time Thank you, mr. Chairman Mr. President, I'm sorry. Thank you. Mr. President and thank you Delegate Coyner for your leadership on the House Education Committee as well as the the chair of the Early Childhood and Innovation committee subcommittee

[00:51:25] Also, just thank you for tending this bill And I just want to recognize that it took a whole lot more than getting it from the beginning of session to the end of session It's taken years of conversations of building your own capacity and knowledge and also Determining how to best communicate that to your colleagues and to stakeholders across the commonwealth So my question my first question is really around that We all want to be ambassadors for this. I know as state superintendent We'll be doing some work to align our work at the state education agency around the science of reading

[00:52:04] Around the priority of literacy education and and I'm really excited for that But that's a little bit of a bubble. And so my question is, just knowing that we want to be ambassadors for this work, what are some of the challenges with messaging that you had as a policymaker with some of your colleagues and stakeholders that we might learn from?

[00:52:27] And then I have one more question, Mr. President. So I think the first is assuming that everyone's speaking the same language. you know, when I first started working on this, I didn't fully understand scientifically based reading research. So I think ensuring that, you know, you have some kind of work session where you all are all speaking the same language is really, really helpful. And that we're not afraid within our agencies and organizations to say, we don't all know what we need to know to move forward. And so let's train ourselves. And so I think that would be, you know, one of the things

[00:53:00] that I learned, I had to do a lot of assuming that other people didn't know what I knew. And we get defensive when we represent, you know, communities and we want them to be the best, we want to brag about them being the best, but to have conversations that we're not the best in some things right now, we have some work to do.

[00:53:19] And so being able to say, here's our problem, and here's our solution, and bringing people along to be part of that problem solving. So I think it definitely helped that we had a solution that we could show work to other places like Mississippi. When I could say I've had meetings with Superintendent Wright and this is where they struggle, these are the things that went wrong, and this is the advice that she gave, and this is how we built it out in our legislation was really, really helpful.

[00:53:48] But I think ensuring that you're all on the same page, so you have consistent messaging leaving your board, leaving the department. I know folks, we all think we know, but we have resources available to us through our PALS office and other places who can really help train the language speakers so that it's not intimidating and it's easy to understand and we're not confusing different stakeholder groups.

[00:54:12] Thank you. Can I ask one more question? Of course. Thank you. Thank you, Delegate. That was excellent and exactly what we have been talking about and why we are so excited for today's work session and moving forward with this work.

[00:54:30] My second question is really about parental involvement. I know that that's an ongoing conversation just in the education world in general, but especially when it comes to early literacy because there are so many things that our parents can be doing to help develop or help enhance children's pre-literate skills and early literacy skills.

[00:54:53] And I wonder, are there any particular parts about the bill that really address parental involvement or fund parental involvement? And we'd love to hear a little bit more about that. Yes, so a big part of the bill is also parents receiving the data and being able to understand it.

[00:55:13] So what we heard loud and clear from our PTA, they were very involved with this bill. So a big kudos to them for giving us that parent voice. And I have to say, our decoding and dyslexia families have been fighting for this for forever. And when I met with them early in the fall and said, "We're going to do it for all," they basically told me they thought I was crazy.

[00:55:34] But they can tell you how much we need to ensure that the data that we are giving to parents, that our teachers know how to explain it so that parents can walk alongside teachers and their students. That was the number one gap, is that they just, parents don't understand these numbers and what you're giving them as results of screeners.

[00:55:58] And also ensuring that we're using and for parents as a platform to grow, right? The language that we speak to our parents, that here are resources that you can also use at home, and this is a journey of growth for your child. And your child can grow in these areas.

[00:56:13] These are the areas within literacy that they're already meeting benchmark, and here's where they can grow, and here's our goal together. And so, providing that, the bill does provide that it is required that they receive that and that we offer those services to students and to parents. And so, it's a big part of the bill.

[00:56:28] So, Decoding Dyslexia Families, PTA, they were a huge part of development of the parent portion of this bill. And I really appreciate the work that they did to ensure that what parents felt like they were missing to be partners was included. Thank you.

[00:56:44] You're welcome. All right. I think that's all the questions. And again, thanks for your time. I would like to mention Juliette Clark. I don't know if you want to recognize Juliette or you want me to do it? - I'm happy to do it. So my first, is she here? - No, no.

[00:57:00] - Oh, okay. I was like, oh, is Juliette here? - Just to explain, Juliette is, you know, now graduated law school at UVA. She also got a joint degree there. She is clerking for a federal judge. And because of that, it was, you know, she could not attend here just in case something ever came before that judge with regard to education.

[00:57:19] So go ahead. So, again, I can't speak any more highly of the UVA law school clinic. I would encourage you all, they're not just available to legislators. You know, they can intern within any government organization, local or state level. But Juliet was my very first law student intern in the public policy clinic with growth assessments.

[00:57:39] And she was actually, when we were talking about the growth assessment bill, this was an issue that she studied for working on it for you all here. And so her initial data was really what allowed me to take this as the next step to say, all right, this is the next bill we're going to tackle.

[00:57:55] And then I just happened to really be blessed that we have some experts at UVA School of Education in this exact field of work. And so I actually texted Juliette. I didn't want to jinx myself, so I waited until after the bill had gone through. And I texted her and I said, just so you know, all of your hard work as a law school student that you laid the foundation for two years ago, three years ago, you know, came to fruition.

[00:58:18] and she was so excited. So, you know, I would encourage you all to look at that law school program. It's very beneficial, and they bring a wealth of knowledge and are really hard workers. So I've had two successful education years, and it is in part to the work of law school students interning with my office, doing a lot of work. Actually, the report she did previously was for her capstone with the Board of Education as a client in literacy, and that the contact with came actually through Dick Howard who was one of her law school professors who you know did a lot of work on the Virginia Constitution and we had some issues that we raised there and everything

[00:58:57] came full circle so she did a great job on this. She did a fabulous job they are and they're great researchers so again this national when we found how we found Superintendent Wright really started from law school students searching across the country and saying where do we where do we go find people to interview and talk to. Thank you. You're welcome. Next year are you going to carry the SOQ bill? We'll see. I have a professional development in fourth to eighth grade early literacy. There's only so many things I can tackle. Carrie, we can sit back down and redo the list.

[00:59:26] We can sit back down and redo the list. All right. Thank you. Thank you. All right. Next up, overview of the Virginia Literacy Act. Dr. Sale. Good afternoon, everyone. President Gecker, members of the committee, Superintendent Bailo. I will admit you will hardly need my presentation after Delegate Coyner's thorough overview.

[00:59:55] But I will do my best to provide a bit of value add here. And I think Delegate Coyner did an exceptional job of really capturing the importance and the purpose of the bill. And my role is to help us kind of dissect that a little bit further and understand our respective roles and responsibilities and helping carry this all out.

[01:00:15] One of the things I think that she also did very well was the scale of work that's in front of us and the dimension that's there. And so I think hopefully this presentation will also help us start to kind of break that down and better get into the different moving pieces and moving components of all of this work.

[01:00:32] And then, of course, following that, we'll hear more from folks, staff members and presentations and speakers that can speak more to the programmatic pieces and the practice pieces that are really going to inform our work over the next several years.

[01:00:49] Much of this slide is really context and background on the legislation, which we've covered with Delegate Coyner, and I'm sure you all are fairly well familiar with the legislation that brought us here together today, being House Bill 319 and Senate Bill 616 carried by Delegate Coyner and Senator Lucas. Before we get into the individual components of the bill, I do want to highlight a few additional pieces of context for us that I think are helpful for the discussion.

[01:01:15] The first being the enactment timeline. So these provisions will come online in the 24-25 school year, which seems like lifetimes away, but it's just around the corner. So we have our work cut out for us in the next few years. As Delegate Coyner mentioned, there are still pending discussions around the budget on how we will resource this work, which includes provisions around how the department will provide both instructional resources, professional development resources, and how we will handle staffing both at the department level as well as the local school division level. Lastly, I will also add that there are two corresponding pieces of legislation that help round out or really reinforce the Virginia Literacy Act,

[01:01:55] both carried by Delegate Delaney, House Bill 418 and 419, one of which touches on how our early intervention reading initiative funds are spent to make sure it aligns with the work that we're doing here, as well as making sure that our educator preparation programs have clear expectations for how they are setting up our teachers in the pipeline.

[01:02:18] So Delegate Coyner gave us a framework around four levers, hopefully what I've done here still helps us kind of wrap our head around all of the different components of the work and doesn't hinder us. I had actually, when I started to wrap my mind around the work, had broken this down into six major components of the bill. And so that's how I have it framed here in the rest of the presentation structured. So again, hopefully helping us break down these individual components and understanding our roles. I will say the way that they are framed here, the pieces here, are really our end stage goals. So So as we'll talk about in later slides, there are a lot of pieces that will come into play

[01:02:55] to help us execute these, but when you see the full implementation of the bill, these are kind of set out as our goals here in these respective areas. So first, as Delegate Coyner mentioned, one of the critical parts that set the foundation and the tone for the bill is the definition section.

[01:03:13] And it's making sure that we have a clear understanding of what evidence-based literacy instruction and science-based reading research mean. And it's so important for us to have a common

vernacular as we talk about this to kind of harken back to one of the themes for a lot of the components of the bill being consistency and how we implement this across the state.

[01:03:32] So in developing these definitions, I think we have a very clear understanding of the foundations, components, and applications of this new approach to literacy instruction in the Commonwealth, which again serves as the basis for all of these other components of the bill.

[01:03:50] Another piece of this is our instruction and intervention programs. And so this is where we're going to see all of these changes and work making a difference at the school level, classroom level, and student level. So we'll see all of these changes having to be well thought out, so there are planning components to how we're going to address our changes and approaches to literacy both at the division level and the student level when we recognize and identify a need for additional intervention students or services for students.

[01:04:20] And as Delegate Coyner mentioned, this part of the bill also recognizes the broader universe of supports that we need for student success in literacy, parents being critical to that conversation. So making sure that they're engaged both in terms of their student's core instruction and that they have the resources that they need to provide support, as well as they're engaged in the intervention process should their student be in need of services.

[01:04:44] Of course, all of this is going to require some additional staffing and the right credentialed folks in our classrooms and our divisions to execute the work so this bill does have a staffing requirement and standard 2 which has a reading specialist in every division at 1 per 550 students and just as a little bit of a reminder and context for us currently there is a reading specialist set out in the code but this is the hiring and staffing is at the discretion of the local school board so this really kind of firms up and cements that that staffing expectation for our local school divisions next I'm gonna kind of

[01:05:21] Address these as a bucket here because I kind of see our professional development and training teacher licensure and educator preparation pieces Three major components as three legs of the same stool so it's recognizing that we need to equip our educators and administrators with the right skills and the right resources to implement this work with fidelity and of course a large part of that infrastructure happening at the institutions of higher education and making sure that our pipeline is is again, well-defined and has clear expectations for how we're preparing teachers and administrators

[01:05:52] for the classroom and for their leadership in the school. As you all can imagine, given the scale of the work in front of us, we are all gonna have a role to play. And when I say we, the proverbial we, that includes our teachers, our educators, our administrators, our parents, and then of course the board and department will have an important role to play in all of this work as well.

[01:06:20] This particular part of the slides are really highlighting where the board and department are gonna be playing roles to kind of cue us up for the next few years of work. These will be the places that you will engage with the work. And of course, kind of setting a timeline for what's in front of us here.

[01:06:40] I will note as we move through the slides, one of the themes that I took away from this piece of legislation is really the value it gave to the board and department as a supporting and facilitator role in all of this work. so we are active partners in the execution of this work.

[01:06:55] And the way we have the slides designed here, you will also see the interconnected nature of our work. So what the board does, the department will build off of and vice versa. And so we wanted to

kind of lay it out in a way that you can see the interplay and interface of our work as staff and you all as the board.

[01:07:13] So to reorganize us again in terms of those six major components, in terms of instruction intervention, as we think broadly about department and board responsibilities, The department is tasked with developing a list of core literacy and supplemental resource practices and programs that are aligned with the science-based reading research as set out in the bill.

[01:07:34] And that list will eventually come to the board here for review and approval. We do know some of our school divisions have the capacity and means to potentially develop their own curriculum or their things that they're already using that already aligned with science-based research. But again, to connect back to that theme of consistency and implementation across the state, those divisions wanting to use curriculum that are not provided on the department approved list will be approved by the department.

[01:08:00] So we make sure all of our students across the Commonwealth are receiving comparable literacy instruction. The bill also sets a new planning requirement for our students in need of intervention services. And this comes in the form of a student reading plan. So when a student hasn't been identified as in need of intervention, there will be an expectation for teachers, administrators and the new reading specialist positions to develop a student reading plan that really kind of creates an individualized program for that individual student, recognizing their needs, tailoring their approach and supports for those students, and making sure that there are clear benchmarks for success and growth

[01:08:38] as they move through the intervention services. The department is tasked with developing a template for those student reading plans to help support divisions in their implementation, and I guess I should say schools and administrators in their implementation of that work. So we'll be providing the framework for that, and the board will be able to issue guidance to really help kind of give substance and meaning to what should be included in those student reading plans.

[01:08:59] And we do have some guiding principles for us set out in the legislation on expectations for what should be included in those plans. Toggling back to kind of the broader picture and instruction and intervention, the department will be responsible for leveraging data and creating a plan that makes sure we're collecting and using the data in a way that's meaningful for this work.

[01:09:25] And we're also being tasked with providing free online evidence-based literacy instruction resources for parents and local school divisions. So again, recognizing that parents are an important part of this puzzle and making sure students are successful and that we need to make sure that they have what they need in hand to do that important work.

[01:09:44] And similar to the student reading plans, the department will also be tasked with developing a template for the division-wide literacy plan. As Delegate Coyner mentioned, this is baked into an existing requirement for our school divisions, which are the division-wide comprehensive plan.

[01:10:00] So now a component of that will need to clearly address their approach to literacy, as Delegate Quinter mentioned, the funding, the approach, reflecting on outcomes, and that will really be an important data point for us as we reflect on how this work is being rolled out in the field and its degrees of success.

[01:10:17] Again, similar to the student reading plan, the expectation for the department is to set a template, so we kind of give the bones, and you all will provide the meat the guidance document that you

will issue around these division-wide comprehensive plans. Next up in our professional development and training category, again starting more broadly, the department will be providing technical assistance which explicitly includes literacy coaching to local school divisions in that professional development area. As Delegate Koiner mentioned, the vision for that is a regional model to make sure that we have kind

[01:10:54] of our tentacles all across the state and the professional development is wide-reaching and all those folks who need it are getting the correct training and as a compliment to that we will also be creating a list of professional development programs that again are aligned with that science-based reading research which will eventually be brought to the board for review and approval i will note one thing not noted here and like the curriculum piece there is an opportunity for for divisions to use things not on the the department approved list but with the expectation that they would bring it to the department for approval to to ensure that

[01:11:28] consistency across the board and then in that last far i guess far left bottom corner um has the board building on a requirement already in standard five to issue guidance on high quality professional development and this is more targeted to specific educator audiences in certain endorsement areas to make sure folks who are going to be really in the weeds on these particular components of literacy act are steeped in that specific knowledge and you'll notice in the next few slides they make reference to certain certain endorsement areas a few different times so i just want to quickly highlight what that entails um so that will include our early and primary education

[01:12:06] k-6 endorsements our elementary education k-6 endorsements our special education k-12 special education deaf and hard of hearing special education blind and visually impaired and our reading specialist endorsements um so those are folks again going to be particularly engaged in in this work and in need of targeted professional development to support the implementation.

[01:12:35] Again in our professional development and training category, we have the department providing resources to local school divisions to not just suggest and flag that professional development is an important part of this project and this puzzle and here are the ways to do it, but actually providing these resources.

[01:12:52] Delegate Coyner and the folks that she worked with on this legislation I think very much recognize again i've talked about the scale of work in a few different ways but that's going to be a big lift for our local school division so wherever we can provide that supporting role and take the burden both in terms of resources and costs away from the school divisions is an important role for us to play so those resources would be provided to divisions so the teachers could get that professional development at no cost and that last um column or row rather i think kind of toggles between the professional development and training category as well as teacher education this would have the department establishing a micro credential program for our

[01:13:32] reading specialist endorsements so with the new staffing requirement we recognize that we'll want more folks with those credentials in the field and we want to make sure that there are a multitude of pathways for folks to get there so the board or excuse me the department establishing that micro credential program is a part of this requirement or this piece of legislation and of course the board will have discretion and how those can be stacked and built on one another to add up to an endorsement for those individuals and lastly in our teacher education and licensure space you'll see this work largely how we function already in terms of regulatory changes for licensure and

[01:14:10] educator preparation programs where we will be responsible for providing staff support to you all to make sure the appropriate changes and the regulations for our teacher licensure and and educator preparation programs are executed. I flagged a few components here that we will need to address or potentially amend in the regulations as we move towards implementation here.

[01:14:31] A part of that is for our candidates for licensure, making sure that the literacy assessment that they take for licensure includes a rigorous science-based reading instruction component. This has actually been something that's, or work that's already underway and something that the board will consider tomorrow, in fact.

[01:14:47] So this is work that's already in progress. And then, of course, even prior to licensure, when folks are in educator preparation programs, that these candidates are not just receiving courses of instruction and study and science-based reading research, but are demonstrating mastery in those spaces as well.

[01:15:07] And I will stop there for any questions before I hand it over to our program experts here. If there are any questions, maybe at the next spot on call.

[01:15:25] Okay, well, I will stay on call then. Thank you. Okay. Jillian, you ready? - I am ready. - Dr. Wright, thank you for hanging in with us this far. So, you know, we appreciate your patience.

[01:15:41] Superintendent Bailo and you will lead us or lead a discussion of state levers to impact positive literacy change. - So I'm just going to open it up and I think Dr. Wright and I have spoken on a couple of panels at the national level regarding literacy and a number of other issues and international, we were in China together talking about career and tech ed and maybe a little literacy as well.

[01:16:05] So suffice to say, Dr. Wright is just so amazing at sharing the story of Mississippi and I wanna cede most of the time today to her. I just wanna just maybe outline a couple of items that lead us to this point as a nation.

[01:16:26] And they begin long, long ago with legislation and efforts at early literacy education transformation that has been successful, but maybe leadership at the state level and the state governance level has not been as prominent in the conversation as it could have or should have been.

[01:16:50] And that's a charge that we took very seriously as state superintendents and at the time, of course, I was serving as state superintendent in Wyoming and also as the president of the Council of Chief State School Officers Board of Directors. We met for a full day in Washington, D.C., in January of 2020, and we talked about the urgency and importance around ensuring that states were able to have some kind of framework, or, you know, we've used the word levers a couple of times, four levers for action in the Virginia Literacy Act,

[01:17:27] six levers or six components within the bill for the department and now we're going back to four levers of action, actionable items that state governance structures, SEAs, state superintendents and state boards can undertake to move forward.

[01:17:45] So board members, you had access to a Nation of Readers which is a report that was the result or the product of our one-day convening in January of 2020. And we managed literacy education as a priority throughout the pandemic.

[01:18:04] And what we knew from almost day one of the pandemic was that the sense of urgency is greater, the sense of, or the importance or emphasis on literacy education and the science of reading was intensified with the pandemic.

[01:18:20] And finally, we, throughout the pandemic, identify more struggling readers at the end of the pandemic than we had before. And so again, the intensity, the urgency and the importance is there. It's more profound after the pandemic.

[01:18:36] You have in Dr. Wright from Mississippi, an amazing leader in literacy, early literacy in particular. And again, I wanna cede most of the time to Dr. Wright to talk about her experiences as a state leader, also as a passionate education leader in Mississippi and how a similar literacy act was implemented there.

[01:19:01] So, Dr. Wright, thank you so much for agreeing to join us today and so excited to turn the reins over to you and have you just tell us about your experience in Mississippi, share lessons learned, and celebrations along the way.

[01:19:18] all right well thank you and thank you for inviting me um i've got a lot of information to share and hopefully we'll have uh time at the end for questions but um uh our what i have to share i think will be impactful as you as you move through this and i'm um emily are you doing my slide deck emily there okay yes yeah we we have uh we have your slide deck managed yes okay so let me just start with and i'll start with the the next slide which is our vision and mission and

[01:19:56] this is something that i've made a habit of doing as a state chief because i'm a firm believer that if you don't know where you're headed you'll never know where they get there and so the whole idea behind our vision in mississippi is to create this world-class educational system for our children so that they can be successful regardless of what they decide to do in life next slide our state board approved the six goals that you see we did not have a strategic plan when i got here and we wanted to make the focus very much so on making sure that all students were proficient and showing growth making sure that all children

[01:20:32] were graduating from high school college and career ready the state had never had an early childhood goal at all and so this was a big step forward for us to ensure that all of our little ones for having access to high quality early childhood programming ensuring that all of our schools had effective teachers and leaders goal 5 making sure that everybody was using data in a way that that was going to move the needle for student achievement and then goal six we have an a through f rating system in mississippi and we wanted to make sure that all of our schools and districts were rated um c or higher next slide this is a slide to show you where we were so when i arrived

[01:21:09] in november of 2013 we were literally at the bottom we education week as you know produces an annual report every year that ranks all of the schools on a variety of indicators and Mississippi had been ranked as an F and ranked as 50th our graduation rate was at 75.5 which was the second lowest among all of our neighboring states and when NAEP came out um they our kids were more than a full year below grade level when NAEP came out and the bad part of that was the assessment

[01:21:44] system that we used to have was not telling the truth and so hence the honesty gap our assessments would come out and they'd say oh yeah you've got about 65 or 70 percent of your kids proficient in reading and then nape would come out and say no it's 22 of your kids so that was a huge piece

for me because i did not want to be the poster child for the honesty gap report next slide so in In 2021, here's where we are, so quality counts now has rated us as a C minus overall.

[01:22:15] We are now 35th in the nation for our K-12 achievement. Our graduation rate is the highest it's ever been at 88.4. And when the 2019 results came out, Mississippi was ranked number one in the nation for our gains in fourth grade reading and fourth grade math.

[01:22:31] In fact, we were the only state in the nation that improved in three out of the four tested areas and I want to talk a little bit more about that when we get there and then over the past three years Quality Counts has ranked Mississippi the second most improved state in the nation next slide so people said well what did you do so there were a lot of levers that we put in place and the first was we reorganized the State Department because it was not organized in a way I felt that was going to move the work forward so once the strategic plan was developed

[01:23:06] And once we had our goal set, we reorganized the department in order to achieve those goals. We also had standards that had been evaluated by two outside organizations. By the time I got there, I think the one word they used was atrocious, and I think the next phrase they used was the worst in the nation.

[01:23:24] So we went about adopting very rigorous standards for our state. In fact, they're the highest the children have ever experienced. And at the same time, we jettisoned the old assessment, which wasn't doing us any good whatsoever, and we developed our own brand new assessment. We put an RFP for it.

[01:23:41] I said I wanted to mirror the rigor of NAEP. I wanted to be aligned to our standards. And so we started with that, and I'll talk about that in a second. We also put into place what I consider a very strong accountability system. I'm a believer that accountability drives the behaviors that you want to see in school.

[01:23:57] So your accountability system needs to be measuring those behaviors that you want to in schools, like proficiency, like growth, like graduation rate, like how many children are enrolled in AP, IB dual credit classes. So that we refined as well. And then a strategy that I firmly believe in, and I was so glad to hear your speakers talk about it, is building teacher and leader capacity. I honestly believe that everybody wants to come in doing the very best that they can, but this idea of a common language and making sure that we all have the same capacity to teach children to read through the science of reading and leaders know what to be seeing in classrooms.

[01:24:36] That was huge for us. So we as a department have taken on the role of providing that professional development statewide. And it was important to me. I used that phrase. Everybody's got to be speaking the same language. Everybody's got to have the same understanding of what we're talking about when we're talking about what does it mean to teach the science of reading or evidence-based literacy.

[01:24:58] So the next slide. So these are the, this came out of the Council of Chief State School Officers, and that was what Jillian was just referring to. And these are four state actions that they're saying can help to move the progress along. And I'm going to talk to each of those as I move through my presentation.

[01:25:15] So let's start, next slide. So let's start first with about the legislation. Next slide. In 2013, there were two laws that were passed that were critical for Mississippi. One was the Early Learning Collaborative Act. had no public dollars going into pre-k in 2013.

[01:25:30] And so this was the first time that public pre-k had any attention whatsoever given to it. And so they put $3 million into the piece of legislation. We have increased it over time, it is now up to 16 million and we've asked for an additional 10 million during this legislative session.

[01:25:49] And we've asked for it based on what I call the return on investment, right? You gave me $3 million, Here's what the return on your investment was, meaning what were the student outcomes for that. And the Literacy-Based Promotion Act, which is similar to your Virginia Literacy Act, really put a focus on K-3 literacy.

[01:26:08] We started at $9.5 million annually. And I said to the folks across the street, there's no way we're going to get there at that rate. So the very next year and every year thereafter, they have given the department $15 million to operate within those bounds.

[01:26:23] Next slide. So let me just talk a little teeny bit about the Early Learning Collaborative Act first, because our efforts have really been a pre-K through grade three piece of work. This, as I said, this was the first time we ever given communities, if you will, the opportunity to open pre-K classes that we had control over.

[01:26:44] And you could pick a lead partner, such as either a district or a Head Start site, et cetera. We gave the money to them. We were responsible for helping them hire the staff and outfitting the program. And we also, we didn't even have an office of early childhood ed when this bill was passed.

[01:27:01] And they say we had to form that at the state level as well. And the other thing I did, because I know that almost all the children in the state come to public kindergarten. So I wanted to be able to give daycare providers, Head Start people, anybody that touch frees and fours, four year olds in the state.

[01:27:19] So we opened up all of the professional development that we were offering for free anybody that types of three-year-old and a four-year-old because I felt if we could build a capacity across the state then we would see better results coming into kindergarten in the next slide and another piece of this legislation that was really really important was this tax credit local businesses were allowed to donate to their local collaborative and get a one-to-one tax credit and you can see we started with less than three hundred thousand dollars the first year being donated and now we are well over six million dollars in money that has been donated by businesses to get this tax credit so it was a real incentive

[01:27:58] and these collaborative were put based on where we saw the least amount of access across the state where our results in our elementary schools were the worst so we wanted to give them the chance to start those collaborative before they even set into our K through 12 programming.

[01:28:19] Next slide. The one thing that we didn't have was early childhood coaches. We did not have parent engagement specialists, et cetera. So we approached the WK Fellows Foundation, which has a big footprint here in Mississippi, and asked if they could fund it for four years.

[01:28:38] And so they did. And we really got a chance to expand all kinds of resources early childhood and also with our families we've even developed a family engagement toolkit and so the one thing I'm gonna say to you and I'm gonna go through several of the resources that we have I'll say it up front so I won't forget it any of the resources we have and I say this no matter who I speak to please go to our website we've developed some amazing resources in literacy and for English language learners and all special education students for this is concerned feel free to pull it down off our website take our name off of it and put your name on it and just use it because we're all here for the same

[01:29:17] interest and that's making sure that our little ones are learning so I kept all this data on our early childhood coaches because I knew that the funding cliff was coming with the with the philanthropic gift and so sure enough when I went back to the legislature and showed them what we had done with these coaches they're now funding our early childhood coaches for us next slide I'm not going to spend a lot of time on this but I do want you I know you're you're using reading specialists we're using coaches and the one thing that i can tell you that i we did a little bit differently uh we as the department hire the coaches and i just heard

[01:29:54] your the last speaker say that you're letting that up to the district um i would make sure that you have a pretty tight job description if that's going to be the local control piece because we're a local control state and i knew that this work i had to have the best quality of the people coaching our teachers and so that's the reason we took control over the coaching model and the coaching strategy for us we now have math coaches early childhood coaches school improvement coaches special education coaches literacy coaches and digital learning coaches and those are

[01:30:29] all under our purview our hire um to push out across the state to help our teachers and that has been um that has stayed off for us tremendously but this will give you an idea of what a coach actually does next slide so as you see um these are the different components that we have in our act um it did provide us professional development money we put out an rfp because we wanted to make sure that the science of reading was being taught it's all k3 general ed special ed and administrators and so um the letters training is what we use i can tell you that our teachers have given us amazing feedback saying it's the best professional development they've ever had uh and we require

[01:31:08] that training now for all pre-k through grade three teachers and administrators and i can tell you that now i heard somebody say we really want to move into fourth through five i'm having fourth through eighth grade teachers saying can i take it because i've got kids that are struggling in reading can we take the letters training as well we had our assessment system built in so we monitor in kindergarten through third grade at the beginning of the year the middle of the year in the end of the year so that not only do teachers know but now built into this legislation a letter has to be sent home to every kindergarten through third grade student that's struggling in

[01:31:44] reading to a parent and it doesn't just say carrie's struggling in reading it says carrie's struggling in reading and here is specifically what we are going to do to help your child get better so the strategies are listed in that and those letters are mailed home to parents every order so the parents are constantly informed um about how their how their children are doing next slide uh we also increased the rigor if you will of the act and i see i think you've done that it's memory serves uh we now require all teachers to pass the foundations of reading um assessment in order to receive their license to become licensed to teach in the state of mississippi

[01:32:23] and also in 16 we modified the law to now require that every student that is struggling has an individual reading plan to help them improve next slide we've done a lot around dyslexia i'm not going to spend a lot of time on that but we started in 1997 with grants to districts to support students we've had added dyslexia scholarships and now this past year we are now requiring all of our districts to participate in dyslexia awareness training next slide this was a big one our law only we've got a five level

[01:33:01] system with one is the lowest and five is advanced in our law when it was passed said children in order to be promoted because it's a promotion law had to pass above the lowest level well all they had to

do is score above a level one and I said we're never going to proficiency at level four if we don't raise the bar so i went back across the street and asked the legislature to move the bar up in 2016. i said give the district three years of a runway but then in 2019 we're going to assess using the higher bar so now in order for children to be promoted they must score to three or higher not quite a proficiency but a

[01:33:40] three or higher uh in order to be promoted unless they have a good cause exemption next slide so this will just give you just an overview quickly of the kinds of things that I've just discussed. Next slide. This slide comes to you from the Foundation for Excellence in Education, that is Jeb Bush's organization, and they have evaluated all the states regarding their reading policies. And so I just offer this to you as information for you. Next slide. So now I want to talk to you a little bit about implementation. Next slide. This will give you just a basic

[01:34:18] timeline of how we get it um there uh this is i can tell you that the lift is big uh and it's big on the department and it's big on the district but it's the work that needs to be done um for our children and this will let you know how we kind of sequence things through next slide i wanted to give you an idea of like what does the budget look like and how much money are you spending on what so out of the 15 million dollars that we get every year about 61 of it is spent on our coaching and our coaching support we also have regional supports as you just heard um described to you as well so

[01:34:53] we've got coaches at the district level we've got regional um coaches that assist as well and then we've got coaches that are back at the department we provide professional development for our coaches monthly so even if the district is um is hiring them i would encourage the department to give some thought as to how could you bring those coaches in even if it was done regionally because you've got a large state like I do in terms of square footage to provide professional development to those coaches to make sure that they've got the help and support that they need as they move through that next slide so you can see there's a lot of moving parts and each one of them is

[01:35:32] critical it's critical that you have support for your teachers they're going to need this for many of our teachers were not coming out of ed prep knowing anything about how to teach reading and I was hearing it from principals and I was hearing it from superintendents so now we've at least guaranteed that we're providing them the information that they need to know how to teach the science of reading we've put a lot in place around early identification it starts in pre-k quite honestly and goes all the way through because early identification and intervention are key as is parent communication and i don't know i can't remember if your law is

[01:36:08] a retention law or not ours was you will never hear anybody in my department talk about retention at all we talk about prevention and intervention because if you can't focus on the retention aspect you've got to focus on what is it we're doing for children each and every day next slide as our scores started to come up and they did I was curious about what I really be seeing in the classroom when I wanted to be seeing so we belong to the Regional Education Lab Southeast and Florida State is their research institution so I called up the director and said could you do a study for me to let me know whether I'm seeing in the classroom because we're spending a lot of money on this and I don't know if I'm

[01:36:48] spending that but are we getting what we need to be seeing in the classroom so she brought her team in and went through our training videotaped hundreds of teachers around the state went back and analyzed all that and called me up when the study was done and she she said are you going to love what we found you are seeing in the classroom the behaviors that you want to see teachers are teaching exactly

what you want them to be teaching and they're self-reporting that the information that they're learning has really improved their practice and I gave you a link to the news release that we did on that and a link to the research paper next slide so as you can see the idea behind when you want to call a reading specialist you want to

[01:37:26] call him a coach the bottom line is what are we doing to move student achievement and sustain student achievement over time because that needs to be like the focus and these are all the things that our coaches are doing next slide we've got ongoing help that we provide every year across the state we do a lot of parent meetings across the state we hold language arts nights and math nights and literacy nights working with our parents we've also developed a I'm gonna call it a lesson plan for a principal that wants to hold a literacy night and so it's got all the materials it's got the step-by-step approach so even if our

[01:38:05] staff isn't there principals across the state can pull that off and we've developed so many resources and i want to talk to you a little bit about that as well oh i forgot about our data coaches we've also got data coaches that we also put in districts that were struggling with literacy and they're there to help teachers use their data to inform their instruction next slide so what's come along the slowest and it's been the most painful quite honestly has been educator prep and i said to somebody i just think that their definition of sense of urgency is a little bit different than my definition of sense of urgency

[01:38:40] um and so they've been the slowest to come along to change anything that's happening so we've kind of backed up and taken a different role on our approval process for their educator prep programs um and so we're we are still working on that um we had a governor's task force that took a look at this and for about 18 months and then day two came out with recommendations so we're following up on that as well next slide so the one thing that i think is really important with this slide is that it's everybody connected together you you i'm so pleased to hear that

[01:39:18] you have somebody said such an advocate in your legislature because that really has to be involved in all this because that's where obviously all your money gets but it's also making sure that the department of ed is seen at the district level um right down to the schoolhouse right down to the teacher's classroom as a support to their work and that's one thing i believe that my job and the job my department is to be in service to our districts i've got a 400 plus teacher advisory council i've got a 100 plus student advisory council i've got about 30-ish super intense advisory council and about 35 to 40 principals advisory council and i meet with

[01:39:57] them on a regular basis to say how are things going and what else can we do for you so that that they can see us as supportive of them. So next slide. Let's talk just a minute about our resources. Next slide. One thing that we did, and parents can download it on the app, we've got a great website called Strong Readers, Strong Leaders, and it helps parents, provides them information and resources, birth through grade five, so they can be wherever they can be, and they've got it right there at their phone to say, to give kids, you know, little quizzes, or ask them to do kinds of activities.

[01:40:33] Um, but that's something that, uh, we've gotten a lot of positive feedback, um, from our parents on that. Next slide. This is on our website. Uh, it, this is a highly, highly used document. Um, I'm, I've been amazed at the number of parents that are, that ask for it every single year. Uh, it's in English and in Spanish, um, and it is kindergarten through eighth grade, and it's all about how parents can help their children, um, at home. Next slide. We've developed a great guide, uh, birth through grade 12 on how to

build firm readers and it's really all focusing on our literacy work and this is to provide all kinds of resources and activities

[01:41:12] for teachers to do in their classrooms as they are working on building literacy skills. Next slide. We've been involved in developing high quality instructional materials and so we developed a high quality instructional materials website. This really really came in helpful during the pandemic because I'd love all those teachers they were dragging everything they could from the internet and whether it aligned or didn't align to the standards they they just were doing the best that they could during the time that we were that we were all shut down so we developed this website and so our department and the teachers for my teachers council and others have vetted these materials in the subject areas that you see so now if the teacher is getting ready to teach a

[01:41:51] lesson he or she can go to that website and know that those materials are aligned to our standards they've been vetted uh and we we have confidence in them so let me just close with a real quick um next slide about some of our outcomes next slide our collaboratives have been so so um successful and we've been recognized by the national institute of early education research for the past at least four or five years it's only one of six states in the nation that's meeting all of their 10 quality indicators next slide our little ones coming in from our collaboratives are outperforming all other children in pre-k classes be they

[01:42:30] private be that head start be they home care be they family center so we are collecting this data I changed the kindergarten enrollment form maybe about five or six years ago and now I'm requiring all parents to let me know where their children were four-year-olds so that when I administer the kindergarten readiness assessment I can disaggregate that data and let us know how well each of those groups of children are doing and I can then also work with my early childhood childhood coaches to deploy them to those areas

[01:43:05] that are struggling and this will give you an idea next slide this is from 2019 and this was a little bit of a shock to the system 5:30 is our is our cut for being ready and you can see where our our public pre-k kids came in but also look at head start and when I published this data I got to tell you I wasn't a very popular person but to me the data are what the data are and you had children that when we first published this back when this is in 19 when I first published this data the only difference between children and

[01:43:45] head start and children that are being kept at home was one point and so that was I think a shock to their system our message was we're here to help you get better we've got early childhood coaches we've got resources we could provide you we've got professional development you can come to all we're interested in is making sure that the quality of the program for these little ones is the best that it can possibly be next slide I talked to you about that third grade achievement these are the scores we children are given three times to pass one is our statewide assessment the second one is another reading assessment

[01:44:20] that is a part of our reading statewide assessment that's given in before school gets out and then the last one is given in August and so these were the pass rates when all they had to do was score at level 2 or above and everybody was so fearful about what was going to happen when I raised the bar but look you had 86% of our kids passing it on the first time around which let me know our teachers were doing exactly what we needed them to be doing in the classroom to get these kids over that bar next slide this gives you a picture of Mississippi it's from 2009 to 2019 this lets you know also the the above the bar

[01:44:58] which you see on grade 4 which is the 33 and the 35 that was the national average at the time and so we've made not where we need to be don't misunderstand we got a long way to go to where we need to be but significant achievement over that 10-year period of time uh because of our singular focus on uh improving literacy and next slide uh this was our rankings um in 2019 as i said we were number one in the nation for fourth grade math and fourth grade reading and our gains but we were third in the nation for our gains in eighth grade math and fourth in the nation for our gains in eighth

[01:45:33] grade reading and over that 10-year period of time we were second in the nation for our gains in eighth grade math fourth grade math and fourth grade reading next slide you can see this is our statewide assessment um you can see every year we were like climbing i i've told people that the pandemic was such a gut punch to mississippi because no matter what indicator we were looking at it was heading in the right direction and i honestly believe that the reason that our dip was not as great as it should be it was not a real cliff in ela because of all the work that we had done prior to that time in building um the capacity of our teachers and our leaders

[01:46:13] next slide um our graduation rate as i said to you is the highest it's ever been next slide um and our dropout rate is the lowest it's ever been and also as i said next slide as i said to you um mississippi has been ranked as i said for three years um steady it's the second most improved state in the nation so i feel like we're on the right track um next slide but i also know that um there's a long way to go and um and that's okay because i think that um i think people are excited to get the momentum uh back in we're we're administering our statewide assessments uh

[01:46:51] starting next month we you know we are right in the middle of nape nape is being administered as we speak uh and those results will be put out in the fall so um excited to be here and more than anxious to answer any questions that you may have and i know that's a lot of stuff i threw at you Thank you so much. I'm sure there are questions. So yes, Dr. Mann.

[01:47:23] Thank you so much for that presentation and congratulations to you for all of the efforts you've devoted to this issue. Comment first. I was really appreciative of just how much you have incorporated really birth forward into your strategy. I think that is such an important um um way to think about this when we consider the importance of those early years of life and the foundation it establishes so i was really it was interesting to see how you weave that throughout the strategies that you articulated and the fact that you brought in community you

[01:48:02] were considerate of wherever children were being served and making those resources accessible so that kids could benefit i was curious uh on a couple of fronts um you didn't talk so much about how you understand outcomes disaggregated and there was a lot here but i couldn't help but wonder if you know you are seeing the same kinds of progress when you sort of you know disaggregate and look across subgroups in your data so that was one question um i really appreciate it too

[01:48:38] you're calling out just the the time it takes higher ed to transition right um you've been able to create pd that's helping your teachers succeed at being able to implement the strategies that support reading proficiency but higher ed is not doing its job of making certain that teachers coming out are really prepared and so i'm curious about that conundrum when you think about up in the ante on assessments that teachers have to be prepared to take in order to be

[01:49:16] deemed qualified to teach when the preparation experience is lacking. And so I'm just curious your thoughts about, you know, how to be thinking about those kinds of issues, given some of the things

that we're going to be discussing here as soon as tomorrow.

[01:49:34] Well, you bring up, I'll take your second question first. So what we have decided to do is we have decided that we are going to start posting the pass rates by institutions on the foundations of reading assessments.

[01:49:50] If our data have to be transparent, then their data need to be transparent. So that's one thing that we're getting ready to do. And we've also built into our new evaluation system a way to get at, to start to get at the curricula about what is and is not actually taking place.

[01:50:09] it's been interesting you've got some people we do I'll speak for Mississippi we've had some people that are still and heard this from professors number one I don't need to come to your training I've already got a doctorate okay and then another one that said I don't need to come to your training because I believe in whole language well let me tell you what whole language is never gonna get you to where you need to get in terms of literacy then they're done that you know that was years and years ago and I'm stunned that people are still advocating for a whole language to be quite honest with you and so we said okay well you know what we're just gonna keep pounding away at it we're gonna

[01:50:48] keep pounding away at it we're not gonna back up and luckily the legislature has been very good in making sure that we've got the money to continue with with that training about the subgroups I'm glad you asked that I did not I in this presentation I have other slides but we've got a huge Mississippi succeeds report card on our website and that has data broken down by district by subgroup for everything that you could ever want to imagine profitable expenditures graduation proficiency growth anything that you want to know is on our website

[01:51:27] under missus our Mississippi succeeds report card and we felt that that was important because we do monitor that data we look very closely at our subgroup data because the one thing that I say to people is that behind every data point is a face and you have got to know who that face is in order to provide the right intervention I said just like you would never give an intervention to all white children you would never give the same intervention to all students with disabilities you would never give the same intervention to all African American students it's got to be individualized and that's the one thing we've worked with our teachers on like when you get your data back

[01:52:03] drill down then to who that face is and then what does that face need because each of those faces is going to need something different and then the professional development that we've come back behind and offered our teachers is then how then do you provide the interventions for those children we've got another um i didn't have this on my slide that i would encourage you to take a look um jillian it's called access for all 2.0 and it is a huge um document that we put together to provide teachers with how to help children that are struggling not only in academically and it's broken down by subject area and giving them strategies but also

[01:52:39] behaviorally and how that to help them in various kinds of behavior so once teachers get the data they need to see who the face is and then how do i plan the interventions behind that but we are very transparent about our data and where we've got a gap we'll admit we've out the gap dr dr right good to see you again and i thank you for your presentation um two key questions one can you tell us about your experience and how you supported your english learners from the state level particularly as we understand more and more english learners are struggling with

[01:53:16] acquiring english and literacy skills needed there on top of their own what we call l1 or their primary language we're seeing more and more students not coming prepared to schools even speaking their primary language so talk to us a little bit about what you did and whatever the data shows i'll certainly look it up as you just said a minute ago but what has been your lessons learned there and your successes and anything you can share with us well we we simply do not in mississippi have enough english language learner teachers and and just and i and i just said okay then who's going to be responsible because somebody's got to be responsible right so we said then it's got to be the classroom teacher that's got to have the primary responsibility for

[01:53:54] these children because they're in his or her care anyway so we've put together um besides the professional development so anytime i say to you we've got a resource document and this one is really this one i'm really proud of we sent it up actually to ccfso and i think they've distributed it um across to the other state chiefs but it's how do we help the classroom teacher address the issues that need to be addressed with english language learners in the classroom uh and not necessarily not in pull out classes i mean i believe there's a reason for that for sometimes but i'm a firm believer that children learn by being included in the class as

[01:54:32] much as possible i believe this about students with disabilities as well i was responsible for supervising students with disabilities for 10 years of my career and i can tell you that where we saw the most growth and i think the same is true for english language learners is when they are in the classroom with their general ed peers and they're listening to the language they're watching the behaviors they're listening to the teacher and they're being exposed to the kinds of things that they need to be exposed to and that um the feedback that i'm getting from the teachers particularly around the the the professional development and the um the guidance document that we put out um has been very positive

[01:55:06] so uh we're monitoring that just like we're monitoring all the other data when we get um our statewide data back thank you and that document jillian i'm sorry that document jillian is on our website as well thank you my second question is talk to us a little bit about the screeners that you used and any changes and shifts around the instructional resources you've used specific resources you've used and what was that process like in terms of how you helped lead superintendents and principals on what to adopt and what to implement so we um we took charge of that um

[01:55:44] we also by that i mean we put out an rfp uh for um screeners um to be in so whoever won that rfp we had to be aligned with what we were doing so our screeners in K3 right now are from Renaissance but we'll be re-adversizing that you know obviously when the when that when that that that contract ends but we wanted to make sure that our screeners were aligned with what we were what we were attempting to do and so that's part of it the other part of it is if you don't want to use that screener you must choose from our vetted list so I pulled together the

[01:56:22] best and the brightest when you know and we took we we whatever that thing is request for information I don't know what the bid is but anyway you send that out people get all their information we vetted all those screeners and now on our website if they choose not to use the Renaissance screener they must choose one of the other screeners that we have listened I believe this I think it's about five of them now because we can guarantee that those screeners are aligned to the science of reading and the work that we're trying to do we did the same thing with dyslexia screeners we've got approved screeners on our website so districts have the ability to go on our website but they must choose from one of the ones on our website

[01:57:02] uh because we know that those have been vetted and are reliable and valid in terms of uh screening for dyslexia thank you everybody else i just want to thank you if i may say i know just one other thing i know this may say we took control of a lot let me just you know we i did not want to leave anything to chance I simply did not and I thought you know we we're a local control state we do not we do not dictate curriculum we've got an approved

[01:57:40] list of textbooks on our website that we really vetted a lot through ed reports etc etc now and the districts know they can go there to see exactly what we're recommending but that doesn't mean that they have to choose from that list but over the years what I've found it's been true is that we have been so steady with our support and so steady with our messaging and so steady with the resources that we've provided that I think there's been a real trust issue that's been built between us so now I think that when I say hey this is something you might want to take a look at or we've just developed this they're really much quicker to do that I think than they would have been years ago so I

[01:58:19] I think that in the team that I put in place I've got amazing people to work in this department there's the world's best and they're always there to to help others I've got a team right now that's helping a team in Alaska I've got a team that's helping a team in California because they our job is to how can we help you get better at what you're doing and impact even more children and so we We do that a lot, but we do it from one, speaking the same language, I guess.

[01:58:51] I'll go back to that, speaking the same language. Superintendent Bailo. Thank you, Mr. President. First of all, Carrie, congratulations. And I've said that before, but it is really amazing to be in this seat and just continue to learn from you as a literacy leader in the nation.

[01:59:14] And you've just done so many great things for the children in Mississippi. so thank you and congratulations. My question, I guess, first of all, just lay out the sort of the state of students in Virginia, and that is we are 44% free and reduced lunch, 68% urban and suburban, and 32% rural and town, small town. That's fairly consistent with the demographics across the nation. And I know that you have some of the same demographics in Mississippi

[01:59:52] with rural schools, with socioeconomics, etc. Would you talk a little bit about the challenges of meeting the needs in some of those zip codes that historically haven't had the same access to high-quality literacy instruction? Yeah, that's a really good point. Well, Mississippi has the largest level of poverty in the nation. Um, we've got, um, and if you're African American, the odds of you living in poverty in Mississippi are almost 50%. So, uh, it's a, it's a heavy lift for poverty. We're, you have a many rural areas of the state and the gentleman from Mississippi

[02:00:32] can tell you, I mean, there's the entire Delta, there's, there's not much there, but flat land. And so one of the things that we've tried to do, and the same is true, quite honestly, for the southwest part of the state and for parts of the eastern part of the state that's one of the reasons we provide a lot of regional work like our professional development they don't come to jackson for pd we set up regional professional development all over the state so that those teachers that live in the delta i'll just stick with the delta know that they don't have that all they probably have to do is just drive to delta state which is probably maybe a 20 or 30 minute

[02:01:09] ride for them to come first to PD so that's the one thing we've tried to acknowledge is that they is the vast geographical area we're making sure that it's available all across the state just like our parent nights our parent nights are all over the state so that we're getting to where the people are and not

expecting them you know to come to us a lot of listening takes place particularly when we look at our data and we're sitting down with principals one one thing that we did do we hired but I'm what we call professional development coordinators and in a State Department I'm sure it's the same as you we only are

[02:01:46] able to hire the same number of people that we get pins from the legislature for well I needed personal development coordinators across the state but I had money but no pins so I went to University of Mississippi and I said if I give you this money will you let me hire 20 people with it they become your employees but then you deploy them to me full time so i was able then to hire a professional development coordinator uh in english language arts math early childhood and special education so as a rural superintendent i could call that professional development coordinator sit down and

[02:02:23] look at the data and say okay from my district or these schools what kind of professional development can you provide and then the professional development coordinator organizes the professional development executes on the professional development and then stays in those schools about three weeks to make sure that the teachers have gotten the hang of what the pd has been done so we've had to use different strategies for different areas of the state um simply because um the accessibility jillian as you just said you know is just not there um we had a huge technology um initiative two years ago

[02:02:59] mississippi connect and we had 200 million dollars that we purchased every teacher and every student a new device and expanded broadband in the hot spot and so we did that it looked a little different in the rural parts of the state than it did in other parts of the state but we've also then moved ahead with that with our digital learning coaches we've used our arpa money to purchase high quality digital content to load onto those devices so that even if children weren't connected with the internet like out in the middle of the delta they still had the content on their devices that they could use and from which to learn so we really tried to use a variety of

[02:03:36] strategies to meet the variety of needs um that we've got across the state thank you superintendent thank you so much superintendent for being with us this is very exciting and congratulations I've got two questions, one is about your early learning.

[02:04:00] How much were you able to expand high quality early learning? So what percentage of your young people are now engaged in some kind of high quality educational experience before kindergarten? And second, related, well, that's, as part of my first question, how much do you attribute your success to that?

[02:04:24] How important is that in your success? Oh, without a doubt, I think what we have done in early childhood has definitely impacted K-12. There's no doubt in my mind. We started small. We only had $3 million.

[02:04:40] I think we started with, oh gosh, I don't know, maybe like 1,500 kids. But I think now we are, with the new monies that are coming in, and we feel confident we're going to get the money we've asked from the legislature, we're going to be in about 900 classrooms um in the fall and um uh so all the pd and the resources and everything that i say for you that that will be provided to the new people coming on board um and we've also overall i'm between let's see between the collaboratives those districts that

[02:05:16] have gone ahead with public pre-k um etc with the public end of it we we're we're getting close to Trying to add this up really quick. We're getting we're getting close to almost half of our four-year-olds i'm going to say That's with the public options. Gotcha. That's what the public option that does not count

private pre-k that does not count family Childcare that doesn't count any of that. That's just strictly public pre-k. Thank you. Uh, and then my second question so I hear you on your you know what you've done. You've taken a lot of control and yet you are in a state like us with a lot of

[02:05:55] decentralized system um and i any more advice for us on how to make that work and in particular i would say around i'm here i think i heard you say correct i if i heard correctly you've just taken over the training and you know basically your statewide at the state level you are dictating what the professional development must be for all teachers uh how did you pull that yes and yeah on that dictating that they all must take this yeah yeah so that doesn't preclude districts because there's still districts that are paying for their own professional development so let me just be

[02:06:32] very clear about that we've not said to them okay this is the only pd that you can have that's not what we've said we've said this is the pd that we know all teachers general ed special ed and administrators need in order to be grounded in knowing how to teach the science of reading or evidence-based reading whatever the term is you want to be using um and that we just we just kind of came out and said this is this is critical and i had i got to be honest with you i have had a board since i've been here that has been very firm and very supportive about that i've had amazing

[02:07:07] ed chairs across the street in both the senate and the house that have been incredibly supportive even though i've got two new newer ones now they've been because once our scores started to really come up people started the belief system really started to change and I think that people thought what we were doing was working and I think they've been at the bottom there was just such a culture of low expectations I think Mississippi had been at the bottom for so long that I don't think people honestly believed that our kids could do that and so when we started putting I thought the right things in place then and our score started to come up then

[02:07:43] people started and we so this is just the K3 I could talk to you also about all reform work we've done at middle and high school at the same time we started at k-3 we also knew a lot of work needed to be done at our high schools and i think that um and those scores started to come up so i think that it's been it's been a two-fold kind of um you know i'm going to call it the pincer approach right we started elementary high and then kind of moved into middle school but um that's really and we stuck to our guns i mean you know if people say well i don't want to do that well you know then we we were kind of transparent about that too right like so so you

[02:08:22] didn't uh you didn't actually it wasn't a mandate but it was we're providing this for free and then the bully you did the bully pulpit plus the financial incentive rather than an actual mandate mostly well let me put it let me put it to you this way i don't know how many people are on the phone but let me put you this way when i first got here when we first did that i i just said it i did i just said it's mandatory okay and somebody asked me the other day they said this is like i don't worry the last place i spoke it might have been in alabama because i was in alabama last week they said so was it mandatory i said well i said it was

[02:09:02] i said and the thing about it was now that i look back on it like nobody like really challenged it you know and so you know now you know now looking back on it but it's so funny to think about they said we but i just i thought let's just say that it is and let's see how far we go and i think i may have had like one superintendent who was just really you know had his nose out of joint and i'm not doing that like you know fine i've got a at that time i had 156 superintendents and i thought if one of them's going to march to

a different drummer so be it as i had a uh an effective schools researcher once told me the parable of the sheep is great for church he said but it is

[02:09:38] not good for school improvement he said so you can't wait till you get them all on board in order to head in the right direction so i've always had that little thing in the back of my mind as i've as i've kind of pushed ahead thank you very helpful mr president if i could add to that um i will uh just just share that the the literacy act for virginia does include professional development that is um selected and delivered at the state level for all school divisions and uh so you know we'll we'll be rolling that out and um thanks to delegate coiner we have the mandate

[02:10:13] we we do we do have the mandate we do have the mandate in addition that's great in addition uh the that's the state board is responsible for approving approving curriculum and um just as recently as the last couple of days i've had superintendents reach out wanting to use their relief funds as well as they're thinking ahead and and thinking about reading curriculum they want to do the right thing they want to get the right professional development they want to get the right curriculum and so i think it'll be really important for us as a state education agency to

[02:10:48] first of all really hone in and identify the professional development that we'll be mandating from the state and for this board to at least conditionally approve a small list of curriculum materials from which school divisions can select if they are planning on using their relief funds of course those are time limited so we would want to make sure that we get those in front of divisions as soon as we can of course with the goal of making sure that that that is broadly accepted and known across the commonwealth in the coming months but in the next couple of months

[02:11:24] i want to make sure that that divisions have the tools and the ability to select both the professional development in the curricular materials if they want to get a jump start and be an early adopter of this. Anybody else?

[02:11:40] I don't see anybody this time. So, Dr. Wright, thank you so much for spending the time with us. Very informative, very impressive what you've done there. You've provided a great roadmap for, I think, us to follow here.

[02:11:56] So we are very appreciative. Oh, my pleasure. And Jillian knows how to reach me and more than willing to collaborate on this and got great people that you know can help you avoid some of the pitfalls so best of luck in your efforts but just know that mississippi is not that far away um if you need a if you need a thought partner but thank you thank you very much okay i think before we go into the next session we may take a quick break that meets the pleasure of the board so we'll be back in 10 minutes very generous with

[02:12:29] the times before we do the panel that's coming up i know delegate corner would like to say a few

[02:26:55] words and lord knows i would never deny carry anything so well that was great listening to all the presentations and i just wanted to clarify a few things since y'all are the record keepers anything that's said here will be on your books so i thought i'd clean up a few items um one you know we met with all k-12 stakeholder groups um so all your folks who probably are most they're usually here right or they're watching you virtually so bass and vsba and pta and you you name all your k-12 stakeholder groups but we also met with higher ed institutions so any

[02:27:31] individual college or university that wanted to meet with us as you were going through the preparing the bill we met with them and i will echo what superintendent um uh wright said that your higher education is going to be your biggest hurdle to jump over um but they are all aware of it so i think that's important for you all to know there's no surprises with this bill for them And I think what you'll find, you know, we have had in the past certain institutions that sort of led the way in literacy and how we understood it as a state.

[02:28:08] And now we have folks who are also doing that again. And so you do have within each of your education institutions kind of some internal fighting, right, amongst professors and literacy. And so I think the bill will help sort of make everybody on the same page. There's been some internal struggles with different professors, as you said, but I have a doctorate.

[02:28:26] So I think you'll see that it helps clear that up. I think the other thing, the question about aligning with the science of reading, your screener, you all have already approved that. So the screener for PAL is being redone. Emily Solari at UVA, who's been overseeing that, you all have already done one of the big hurdles in the bill.

[02:28:45] So I don't want you to think that's work that has to be redone because of the bill. And the last thing I will say, while the full implementation is in year 2024-25, the budget money can start being used next year. So I didn't want you to think all of this is on hold until then.

[02:29:01] The way we crafted that budget amendment, all the preparation work can start taking place. And really, really critical with those ARPA dollars, that school division, the only piece of this that they have to pay for is that curriculum because we knew they could take it out of money that they all have.

[02:29:19] and this is the perfect use for those dollars. So that was the only piece that wasn't fully funded. Everything else is fully taken care of as part of the budget. So I just wanted to make sure, as I heard folks talking about those items, that there was clarity on what we put in for the budget as well as the bill.

[02:29:35] Great. Thank you so much. Thank you. All right. Comprehensive overview of literacy in Virginia. Distinguished panel. Good afternoon, President Gecker. Yes, we are a panel. We are a panel, definitely. good afternoon president gecker superintendent baloe and members of the board thank you for the opportunity to come speak with you this afternoon about an overview of literacy in virginia my name is jill noguerris and i am the k-12 english coordinator here in the office of humanities in the department of learning and innovation and i have my two esteemed colleagues with me this

[02:30:13] afternoon our elementary english and reading specialist carmen curick and our middle school specialist Colleen Casada. We are a small but mighty team of three, but we are very pleased to have this opportunity to connect with you this afternoon. At the request of the board, we did write a 40-page report giving you an overview of literacy in Virginia, and it is our hope this afternoon that this presentation will just provide some insights and just some details about what we included in there. It is rather comprehensive and probably would be hundreds of pages printed out if you explored all of the links that were

[02:30:51] included as well so this is a very broad overview but we are happy to answer questions on specifics if we are able to do so this afternoon all right so hopefully that works thank you for the opportunity to come and speak with you this afternoon on such a massive and important topic as literacy here in Virginia as former reading specialists literacy coaches central office staff and parents here in

Virginia, of students and kids ranging from 8 months old to 14 years old, we find this to be an incredibly important aspect of our work and our leadership and

[02:31:30] our involvement and support of school divisions here in Virginia. So just wanted to provide you the overview kind of what we hope you would want to know. We realize that we may not have covered everything and we do realize that because literacy touches so many aspects and other offices in the department our overview will be looking at tier 1 instruction but we do have some support and friends in the office from the office of special education early childhood assessment teacher licensure to address any other questions that we can as we move through our time this

[02:32:06] afternoon so just to give you an idea about what we talk about when we talk about comprehensive literacy in virginia we like to start by thinking about the goal the goal of literacy instruction in virginia is to ensure that all children have the necessary skills to become successful readers writers speakers and listeners with the critical thinking skills that are required to be successful after graduation our program so the english program here at the department of education utilizes the term comprehensive literacy to demonstrate the instructional approach

[02:32:43] of integrating the four strands of our 2017 english standards of learning the 2017 english standards of learning curriculum framework the context of real-world application the occlusion of interdisciplinary content and scientific-based research in k-12 language arts as you may be aware the english standards of learning were the first standards to be developed under the profile of a virginia graduate as such our current standards include a specific focus on virginia's five c's

[02:33:19] communication collaboration critical thinking creative thinking and citizenship four of which were already in our standards so adding in the citizenship was a natural connection but this is evident within our four strands which you see highlighted here on the board our strands within the english language arts standards are reading writing communication and multimodal literacies and research these strands work together to promote and support literacy development k-12 and as teachers of english we are very much interested in symbols and themes and you're

[02:33:57] going to see a lot about ropes today so if you're kind of looking at that curriculum framework example right there you'll kind of see the idea of looking down a rope and the interlocking symbol there of these things working together to promote literacy for our students and again because we needed to kind of consolidate the information that was shared today while our report isn't numbered by page number all of the topics were hot linked if you are looking at an electronic copy so if you wanted to look more about the history of our standards our revision process how that works you can find that on pages four through eight of your

[02:34:37] report or in the links that were included on the index on page 35. so something that we want to always think about at the forefront of our minds when we are thinking about english language arts is that our standards are a progression of skills that start spiraling in kindergarten and move all the way up through 12th grade so concepts that are introduced as early as kindergarten are still concepts and skills that we grapple with and utilize within our toolboxes as 12th graders

[02:35:12] one unique aspect about k-12 language arts is that because we are a skills-based course and not a specific course or content we do not have anything that is taught in one year and covered within a specific course that is not explored again down the line which i will show you an illustration of on the next slide but the spiral is important to keep in mind as we consider the effects of the pandemic on our young

learners and the different variety of entry points at which they're entering our classrooms right now so we like to speak with our supervisors and our division

[02:35:50] level leaders and our teachers and really talk about utilizing the grade levels before and after when teachers are looking at the curriculum framework for the scope of learning in each of the strands to connect where students might need some additional support but also to think about where students are moving next as we have students sitting in our classrooms that kind of need a a variety of supports. So just to give you a very brief simple example to kind of illustrate our point about the English skills progressing over time and spiraling and spinning as they go through,

[02:36:26] I have included a setting example just because that's really easy. And what you see here is in second grade, we expect that our students are able to describe the setting. As they are learning to read, they can describe the setting in a work of fiction and poetry. But once they are in fifth grade, you'll see that that standard jumps to discussing the impact of setting on plot development. Now, without being able to identify or describe that setting, they would have a difficult time explaining how to discuss the way that the setting impacted the plot or impacted

[02:37:03] the decision of a character. Moving up into seventh grade, you'll see that students are expected to describe the elements of narrative writing, including setting, amongst a variety of other pieces, and how those pieces influence one another. So how did the setting impact that character development? How did the setting impact the theme? How did the theme impact the setting? What did the author do there? And then if you look in 10th grade, you will not see the term setting at all.

[02:37:34] Because we are a K-12 course that's built on skills, if we wanted to include everything that a student would be responsible in 12th grade, then we would need to include all of the kindergarten standards all the way through. As you can see in 10th grade here, we have that students would be able to critique how authors use key literary elements.

[02:37:55] We don't need to write out studying anymore because it is assumed that students have a lot of practice and experience with that and could pull that out of their toolbox. So it is our job as educators in Virginia to make sure that our students have the necessary tools that they need so that they can select the appropriate tool and know how to use it and when to use it to read and comprehend what they are reading.

[02:38:21] So when we talk about comprehensive literacy here in Virginia, we're talking about integrating the strands of English language arts to enhance and cement student understanding. So while those strands are developed separately, they are expected to be seamlessly integrated in a classroom.

[02:38:44] And when strands are woven together, they are stronger, much like the image of the rope that you see here. And when our students have experiences where they are making these linkages between vocabulary and reading and writing and research, then they are able to strengthen their understanding of what they're reading and their student outcomes improve.

[02:39:09] So when we talk about just some generic English instruction, some effective practices, this is a lot of what we talk about, is pairing text, having students compare and contrast what they see in different types of writing use of text-dependent questions where the answer doesn't just come from their head but they need to go back into the text to kind of pull out that knowledge using inference questions and text-based vocabulary and including writing incorporating writing in every uh every lesson if appropriate however in order for our students to be successful

[02:39:46] with paired text and text-based vocabulary and text-dependent questions they need a strong foundation in these early literacy skills so at this time I'm going to turn it over to Carmen who is going to speak with you now about the science of reading and its role in k-12 literacy instruction here in Virginia good afternoon president Gecker superintendent Baylow and board members as Jill mentioned my name is Carmen Kurek and I'm the elementary English and reading

[02:40:24] specialist here at the department and I'm excited to have the opportunity this afternoon to share the science of reading with you just to hopefully create start the conversation and having a shared understanding explain some models that illustrate larger components of what instruction looks like under the science of reading and to share some snapshots of research underneath the science of reading as delegate coiner mentioned before the science of reading is a very broad term so we really hope to just illustrate those larger components of what instruction looks like that is aligned with science and

[02:40:59] evidence-based practices so what is the science of reading if you happen to Google science in any sort of context that has to do with a career field most of the definitions that you will find center around center around this idea of a systematic organized body of knowledge and research around a particular topic and that is the topic that we are exploring today this systemized system a systematically organized body of knowledge and research around literacy and reading.

[02:41:34] And this research has been growing for the last 50 years on how the brain learns to read and how children need to be taught to read. And so that is what we will be exploring a little bit more today as well. And you can see how the International Literacy Association defines the science of reading on your slide as well, similar to what I just shared.

[02:42:02] So we did want to share a few snapshots of research that support the science of reading. So I will share what it says and then hopefully provide some examples to illustrate what that might look like in a classroom. This particular snapshot of research comes to us from, it's called an IES practice guide.

[02:42:19] It is published by the Institute of Education Sciences through the What Works Clearinghouse through the U.S. Department of Education. And this particular educator practice guide was written to share evidence-based recommendations of how children should be taught to learn literacy for those foundational skills in kindergarten through third grade.

[02:42:41] So you can see the points listed there, and I will kind of go through them and then hopefully share a few examples and not talk all day about them. But the first one is teaching students academic language skills, including the use of inferential and narrative language and vocabulary knowledge.

[02:42:58] And then develop awareness of the segments of sounds in speech and how they link to letters. Teaching students to decode words, analyze word parts, and write and recognize words. Ensure that each student reads connected text every day to support reading accuracy, fluency, and comprehension.

[02:43:16] So just to touch a little bit more on these. So really working through building students' language skills. And those early grades were really working on their listening comprehension, how they understand the stories they hear, building their oral language skills, their sentence structures, the words that they use, their vocabulary knowledge.

[02:43:33] So this might look like a lot of read alouds to build background on a certain topic, really helping students to summarize what they're reading and make predictions about what they're reading so later, as Jill mentioned, they can have those complex conversations around complex text.

[02:43:49] And then developing awareness of the segments of sound and speech. So in the English language, there are 44 sounds, and there are 144 different ways to represent those sounds. So that is a challenge that, you know, teachers are hopefully tackling in their classroom is teaching all the different ways that we represent those sounds.

[02:44:08] We are not born with the ability to read, but we are born with the ability to speak. And, you know, when infants start babbling and making those sounds, we are living this in my house right now, but you're like, oh, I heard me. So really, once they get into school, taking that next step and showing them how to represent those sounds.

[02:44:29] Teaching students to decode words, those are really working on those common spelling patterns that we know, working on word building activities, teaching students those high frequency words and what patterns they may go with, those natural spelling patterns, but if they do not fit a pattern, matching how it is spelled to the sounds that they hear in the word.

[02:44:49] And then reading connected text every day. early grades with early readers, this looks like they would be reading with a decodable text. So you would see a student with a text that has a lot of those common spelling patterns that they're working through so that they can apply the skills that their teachers are teaching them through a reading, through an actual book and text. So you've probably heard that phonics instruction is a huge piece of science-based instruction. And it is, but we also hope you help to share today that there are

[02:45:24] other large components as well and how they work together. So this piece of information comes to us from an International Literacy Association Literacy Leadership Brief from 2019. They shared what are the characteristics of effective phonics instruction and so again I will do similar share that them and then touch more on a few of these. So effective phonics instruction should be explicit and systematic, focus on those strong readiness skills in the early grades, follow a scope and sequence, focus on blending, dictation, word awareness, high frequency words, reading connected text, and building vocabulary and background knowledge.

[02:46:04] So I wanted to highlight a couple really important ones that I believe set phonics instruction apart under science and evidence-based practices. And the first one is that it is explicit and it is systematic. So when we think of the word explicit, it means we start the lesson by telling the students what we want them to know. We directly state it. Boys and girls, the sound is represented with the letter S. First graders, this week we're working with the A sound and we're working with how it is represented with an AI. We tell them what we want them to know, not asking what are we learning this week and then often, you know, hearing crickets or then there's a guessing game. We explicitly tell

[02:46:42] them what we want them to know in a familiar way every time we introduce this concept and that it is systematic. There's a structure and a sequence to every day how we work and how we work through these skills in our classroom. It follows, it goes from simple to more complex skills. There's a structure to the lesson of how we introduce, how we practice, and how we apply those skills in our books and in our writing. And then really honing in on the building vocabulary and background knowledge. We don't often think of vocabulary and background knowledge as having a strong correlation to phonics instruction but it is a huge piece to helping students put that together

[02:47:20] if i have read the word cat if i have worked really hard to segment those sounds and say i have never seen a cat never read about a cat never heard of one then they're still just a bunch of sounds to me so

really building that vocabulary and background knowledge so that when students are reading the words they immediately have some background to connect it to and that's what's going to kind of ingrain that word and those sounds into their memory so

[02:47:48] that's a huge piece as well I know that we are specifically focusing on reading today but it is also very important that we cannot forget writing in this context so this what research says about writing instruction comes to us from an additional Institute of Educational Sciences educator practice guide on teaching writing in elementary schools so just providing that daily time for students to write teaching them to write to the for a variety of purposes in specific go through that process teaching students to become

[02:48:25] fluent with handwriting spelling sentence construction typing and word processing and creating that engaged community of writers and I wanted to touch on number three quickly most of these probably speak for themselves but number three really teaching students to become fluent with handwriting spelling and sentence construction and typing and word processing when we are you've probably seen an early learner in your life that will scribble and scribble and will tell you the longest story that you've ever heard with so many details and we know as students get into elementary school and begin to represent their thoughts through print if they do not have

[02:49:02] that fluency with forming their letters then they start they begin to change what they want to say so it is important that as we're introducing letters to students and these patterns of letters that students do have that explicit instruction and handwriting because it really connects how it's formed, how it sounds, and how it looks in their brain to create that fluent writer so it doesn't change what they want to say.

[02:49:26] And the same goes for typing and word processing as well. Probably the most influential piece of work around teaching a reading in our nation is the National Reading Panel Report that was published in 2000.

[02:49:42] The panel was established by the U.S. Congress to really explore how to teach reading across our nation. And we know out of that report came five focus areas of instruction around literacy: phonemic awareness, phonological awareness, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension.

[02:49:59] And as stated in the In Nation of Readers report, growing research throughout the years has really established the not only importance of these, but how interdependent they are on one another, and how they really, they depend on one another to kind of make each other successful, much like building vocabulary really – phonics really – excuse me, really depends on that vocabulary background as well. This chart is separated into those – they're commonly known as the five pillars. Those five focus areas are commonly known as the five pillars

[02:50:39] of reading and the standards of learning – or the five pillars, excuse me. And this chart really shares where the 2017 English standards of learning in Virginia fall into those five pillars, which one they most closely align with just to show you how those do echo in our standards.

[02:50:55] This visual that I will share on your screen is called the simple view of reading and it is a math problem. So for all of you mathematical thinkers out there hopefully this will help to illustrate the point but you do see we have in the orangish yellowish box decoding which really means reading unknown words. There's also the reciprocal process that's encoding which means learning to write and spell

unknown words we have language comprehension what really which really embodies listening comprehension vocabulary the oral language the

[02:51:34] sentence structure all of those things that we know support that decoding and then at the end reading comprehension so it's very intentional that this is a multiplication problem and not an addition equation for the purpose of if it was addition and we were missing one of those components we could potentially still have a sum at the end but we know it is multiplication so what if one of those products is missing then we will not get that firm reading comprehension at the end so hopefully this just illustrates how dependent each of these

[02:52:04] components of instruction are on one another now we want to expand the simple view even we know we know there's nothing simple about teaching reading but just to expand the simple view a little bit and share another model that illustrates this point this is called Hollis Scarborough's reading rope she is a psychologist and literacy researcher but you can really see as Jill shared our theme of ropes today but you really see those two large concepts that we've

[02:52:41] shared before language comprehension and word recognition with their underlying components underneath as far as background knowledge vocabulary and then phonological awareness decoding all those underlying skills and you can see as the threads begin to weave together under word recognition as all of those skills begin to come together this what creates a fluent reader they're gaining more accuracy and automaticity in their reading and then as those threads of language comprehension begin to weave together students become more strategic in the use of their language and their comprehension with text and then those two sides weave together to hopefully create that skilled reading so

[02:53:18] now I'll do an overlay of the simple view with the reading rope just to show you how those align. So to sum up this section of our presentation today just to share some key practices that demonstrate research and evidence-based instruction. So if you were to walk into a classroom that are aligning their practices to this research, these are some of the things that you would see. So direct instruction of decoding, encoding, comprehension, and a wide reading of literature to really, as we stated before, build that background, build those

[02:53:58] language skills and teach students to effectively read unknown words and write and spell unknown words. Having that specific focus on phoneme awareness, so those individual sounds and words, as well as its connection to reading unknown words and writing unknown words. Systematic and explicit and intentional instruction on the spoken and written form of the English language, moving on up from sounds to bigger parts of words to words themselves. And then direct and and incidental vocabulary instruction, using text to explore word meanings.

[02:54:29] Really pulling groups of words from the text that students will read to provide that context around those words for students. And then emphasis and intention on building background knowledge and listening comprehension through text, multimedia and other print resources. This could look like in Virginia, if I am studying contributions of Virginians, I might need to have some background on the word contribution.

[02:54:52] So we would read a lot of texts around what a contribution is. We might keep a class list of the different contributions that we've seen in our school, in our classroom, in our community. Lots of different ways to build that background to make that vocabulary stick.

[02:55:07] So as Jill mentioned, we do support K through 12 instruction in Virginia. So we did want to touch on what instructional practices look like beyond some of these early foundational skills. As Jill mentioned before, the 2017 English Standards of Learning have four strands, communication, multimodal literacies, reading, writing, and research.

[02:55:28] And these do really work together to create those readers, writers, thinkers, communicators that we hope to create in Virginia. So we do have a visual to illustrate what this looks like.

[02:55:44] We've used this a lot with the educators that we've talked to and worked with in the most recent year. Really to share, you can see each strand is color-coded there in its own box. reading is red, writing is green, and so on, and then these bubbles that are also color coded to their correlating strand, and they have kind of floated off to match with another strand to really show how our strands integrated, to really show how comprehensive literacy is built to create communicators and critical thinkers.

[02:56:15] So one example might be in grades three through five, you can see there's a little bubble It talks about synthesizing information through print, oral resources, multimedia, and it's stuck to the reading strand. To really share, in fourth grade, students are just beginning to analyze paired text.

[02:56:34] So this is a natural integration of where research would integrate with reading because students will just be beginning to have those conversations across more than one text. And then they can do this through the research that they're doing in their classroom. I am going to share with my colleague Colleen Cassida, and she is going to take us from early literacy and beyond into adolescent literacy.

[02:56:58] Thank you. Thank you, Carmen. Good afternoon, President Gecker, Superintendent Balow, and Board. I am going to, as I said, I'm Colleen Cassida, I'm the middle school specialist here at the department.

[02:57:18] And I'm just going to briefly share with you and discuss the connection, there we go, connection between a strong foundation of early literacy and adolescent literacy development focusing on how in virginia we incorporate that vertical articulation in literacy throughout k-12 instruction i will say for additional information on how we address this continuum i will refer you to the index section of our report on page 30 38 again they're not numbered but in the index

[02:57:52] Section under guiding resources for video II and this is where you can find the link to the Institute of Education Sciences practice guide It's also a practice guide like Carmen mentioned, but this is particular to a effective classrooms And intervention practices for adolescents So as Carmen mentioned in her overview of the science of reading and then Jill addressed in the progression of the Virginia standards Students must have opportunities throughout early literacy to develop all aspects of Comprehension and you will see some of the components that were discussed already

[02:58:31] Echoed in adolescent literacy instruction. This is something also that that Derek Steiner talks about in his work from John Johns Hopkins University regarding k-12 the k-12 continuum and its connection to the science of reading So as students progress from early childhood to adolescence, literacy skills become more complex and they require the application of all the skills that students have acquired throughout development.

[02:58:59] So the National Council of Teachers of English published a research report in 2018 in an effort to acknowledge those complexities of reading as an ongoing and developmental process beyond just the

elementary level. These four components here of the research, they outline or define those complexities that emerge during adolescence.

[02:59:23] And so we're just going to talk about this briefly so there's some context in where we see that early literacy foundation come forward. So when we talk about disciplinary literacy instruction, academic reading requires special reading strategies to access complex text.

[02:59:40] And this is something that happens as students progress into those 6 through 12 grades. So teachers then have to model how students, to show students how to read within different academic disciplines. And then when authors write, as we know, for different audiences and purposes, their structures and styles change.

[03:00:01] And so it's important for the content area teachers to model for students how to read and analyze text written for different content purposes. so that's really important technology as we know this second bullet and social media if anyone has any relationship of any kind with a teenager we know has drastically changed the definition of literacy in the last few decades so text now comes in such a variety of forms and teachers now have to show students how to interact with all of these forms to include bias validity credibility and

[03:00:39] and also how to put different texts together to strengthen an argument or point of their own. So we see this in our Virginia standards, in K-12, to help build these skills as students learn to read and then become readers to learn new knowledge.

[03:00:55] So adolescent readers need sustained experiences with diverse text in a variety of genres and structures. And this is something that Louisa Motz talks about in her work on the science of reading, that students need to be exposed to a variety of genres at an early age, and these texts should be introduced using systematic, explicit, and engaging evidence-based strategies.

[03:01:23] Because as students are exposed to different styles of writing, and then they begin to grow as readers, we wanna provide them with opportunities where they have choice and voice in independent reading and in class reading to increase that motivation and engagement in text.

[03:01:40] So this final point here is what the research here means by multicultural literacy is the seeing, the thinking, the reading, the writing, and the listening and discussing in ways that critically confront and bridge those social, cultural, and personal differences.

[03:01:57] Because this is the level of complexity in literacy that students will be faced with, which is why the CATO standards include the support from the other strands to develop reading comprehension skills that will help them attain the level of analysis and synthesis that are needed to be literate adults.

[03:02:17] So that's really important when we think about this continuum. Okay, so this next slide here is just, it's talking about part of the research and evidence provides evidence-based practices that truly get at the heart of what good readers should be able to do.

[03:02:36] And these practices are essential in connecting the science of reading in K-5 to what happens when students have to adapt new context throughout their literacy development. So readers have to be able to think about their thinking. And that research shows us that once students shift to reading for knowledge, they have to be able to synthesize and determine which strategies will help them engage and tackle a piece of text, whatever that text may be.

[03:03:04] And that's something that Carmen and Jill have both talked about, both in the broader sense of science of reading, but also in our K-12 continuum here in Virginia. So as we think about the progression of our skills in K-12, we have to build those opportunities in, starting before the switch from learning to read and moving to reading to learn.

[03:03:24] To be successful community members, students need the space and the time to learn how to recognize all of these components of bias, credible sources, and how to determine when to believe what they read. So this also is accompanied with text structure.

[03:03:40] It goes hand in hand with writing instruction. And again, writing instruction impacts our reading comprehension, as Carmen mentioned, and we have seen in our standards. So this final little set of the overview here of the connection between K-5 and early literacy moving into adolescent literacy, we see here that Dr. Darling-Hammond's research suggests that students have to understand that bigger picture of why they read and how they consume knowledge understanding why they use certain strategies to support their understanding

[03:04:18] so again thinking about our continuum and just the continuum in k-12 literacy how we get our students to reach this level of literacy and become those independent thinkers it starts at the beginning with teaching those foundational skills through evidence-based practices explicit and systematic practices as well and i just want to say as the the kind of the link between early literacy and moving forward, we look forward to the opportunity to continue this work on the science of reading throughout K-12 as we develop our resources here in the Commonwealth.

[03:04:54] And I'm going to turn it over to Dr. Sam Hollins who will share some of this work and information on science of reading. Thank you guys so much. It's lovely to be with you this afternoon to talk with a topic that's very close to our heart. Now I know I'm going to share perspective from special education, but I really want you to view this with an open mind.

[03:05:13] much of the work that special education has provided has really supported not only special education teachers but our general education colleagues and really given them a deeper understanding of what reading instruction can look like in special education we're taught from a variety of perspectives to embrace explicit instruction and in the case of reading explicit instruction is very helpful you saw a little bit of background to that previously we have the the mantra that explicit instruction is good for all and harmful for none and so it really is a core tenet of the practice that we use not only to help educators become more prepared but then really thinking about how we structure professional development opportunities so that cornerstone of

[03:05:50] our literacy instruction is really embraced in the new literacy act we heard about earlier 82 000 students were below benchmark indicating an increase of just over 36 000 students which is a significant increase from our pre-covid results of spring 2019. this number is far above the the approximately 55,000 identified students with a learning disability.

[03:06:12] This is not a special education problem. This is an education problem, and one that we're seeking to address through a lot of the work that we've done over the past number of years if we focused on a science of reading. Now, I know this slide is busy, but I really urge you to read a little bit more about some of the initiatives we've put in place, particularly with the gains we've been able to make in working with colleagues boots on the ground out there teaching our students and coaching our teachers.

[03:06:35] We've continued to partner with higher ed institutions. to meet outside beginning in 2020. Subsequent to that meeting, we've had two literacy summits and a third is in the planning stage. We're well aware of that collaboration that needs to happen with our higher ed partners.

[03:06:51] And we really work closely with some great colleagues across the state. We heard mention of Dr. Emily Solari. We work very closely in special ed with Mary So out of William & Mary University. There are folks out there in the higher ed community that are eager to embrace this work. And so how can we help to develop this conversation among their colleagues and really further the planning that we're able to do.

[03:07:10] It's possible for us to think about the folks that we've trained here include general education, special education teachers, as well as reading specialists. They had not only participated in this professional development that we've offered across things like multisensory literacy instruction, letters, Orton-Gellingham endorsed framework, but these folks have embraced this as a way of teaching and creating and replicating this practice in the field.

[03:07:33] And so as we think about a willing army of implementers this work we already have boots on the ground started and i think we talk about some of these positions like our regional literacy coach positions we see the value of folks that are already out there doing this work and i'd like to put a special plug into the special education endorsed teachers who are also reading specialists they bring a unique lens and we really see bang for our buck when we talk about those practitioners in detail one of the things that i've learned over my 18 years in special education is that it's great to talk about research it's wonderful to talk about legislation but you know what's really great to talk about is how we implement it in classrooms day in and day out high quality research focuses on

[03:08:12] the importance of going beyond education training and professional development and into implementation translating these findings into classroom based practices is our ultimate goal and responsibility I have the pleasure of meeting with special education advocacy organizations on a quarterly basis hearing directly from parents of students with dyslexia about the challenges that they're having in early education and through k-12 we work really closely with some of dr uh salari's colleagues and one of them in massachusetts talks about the need to move to from a reactive model to a proactive model where we are trying to find the people who will most likely develop problems and help them before they struggle so much and nowhere is this more important

[03:08:52] than talking about our early learners and a focus on reading because we know what the long-term impacts are if we don't get kids quality reading instruction at a young age it was really great to hear from the two state superintendents today because we've taken that work in the report from ccso and have worked with higher ed as well as a partnership with the scaling up evidence-based practices centers to really think about now in special ed we spent a lot of time over the last few years training up these folks cranking out good resources what are we doing to actually build capacity in school divisions and so we're working with a team of providers to build and implementation framework working in partnership with our school divisions through multi-tiered

[03:09:30] systems of support we have we have a collaboration of the willing there let's focus when they've identified reading as an area that they want to learn more about and get better at how can we bring all of this together so that we're seeing that implementation happen at the classroom level and so you know i'm going to tee up jenny here jenna and i will tell you in our work that it takes time to affect that systemic

change and we are really willing to join in this work with our colleagues i really appreciate delegate corner's presentation you know she mentioned the focus that she had in this language and over time we see that terms shift and change right more research happens we know better what to do we can do better instead of being so tied to terms let's

[03:10:07] think about the more the time passes and research develops the better we can get at applying this practice in the field jenna excellent good afternoon jenna conway deputy superintendent for early childhood care and education i am so excited to hear all of the conversation about early childhood and the important role that it plays in building the foundation for early literacy from mississippi as well as across the country and i just wanted to take a few minutes to talk about how the work over the last few years has laid that foundation and so virginia

[03:10:46] thanks in large part to the leadership of this board in addition to delegates like delegate coiner is in a really good place to kind of bring these strands together and provide more opportunity to our littlest learners so many of the things in the materials you received wanted you to know that there are explicit sections on early childhood and we have been thinking about how the five key skills articulated there also relate to early childhood right looks different uh more playful i would say in a word in the early childhood space but thinking about how we're intentional with earliest early literacy is critical if you think about how many of those words and you heard

[03:11:26] carmen talk about even babbling how that all lays your foundation for uh learning to read i also wanted to talk about kind of connect the dots for you on some of these other efforts some of the other things you heard in dr wright's discussion of the law and what has happened in mississippi when we heard from leslie and delegate coiner about these pieces in place some of these are in place in early childhood in fact we had the opportunity to work with delegate coiner as well as colleagues at eva and other institutes of higher education when they were planning this last year and we were able to say some of these things are already underway thanks to the

[03:12:06] legislation from 2020 and early childhood right so creating this expectation that we've got a uniform measurement and improvement system a key piece we have uh you know sort of building off PALS, the Virginia Kindergarten Readiness Program, which looks at the beginning and end of kindergarten, and now we're expanding for four-year-olds, so beginning and end of pre-K, and we're starting to step into three-year-olds, sort of slowly and thoughtfully.

[03:12:29] But that gives us kind of a key indicator on literacy at a broader scale. We, with working very closely with this board, redid our early learning and development standards, of which early literacy, thinking all the way back to birth, so you have infancy, toddlers, preschool, later preschool, laying out what those explicit skills look like.

[03:12:53] When we heard Dr. Wright talk about the rigor, and I think we had really good engagement with this board, in particular with Dr. Mann, about kind of getting that right because we understood that that laid the foundation, again, across our incredible array of programs. And we're not just talking about pre-K in schools.

[03:13:10] When you think about the chart that Dr. Wright showed, right, with all of the different colored pencils one of the awesome things in virginia is now this board and the department of education get to influence all of those family child care head start child care faith-based child care early childhood special education and school-based um uh pre-k anything that's publicly funded and then lastly vqb5 and link b5

and i know that there are so many acronyms and illustrations this afternoon but just give me a moment to kind of explain how this also fits in the law enables us to get into every classroom and to get an understanding of what is

[03:13:49] going on right that's the measurement and improvement system we'll be coming back to you all next month with plans for practice year two but a big part of that is supporting the use of curriculum across all of these classrooms right and really being intentional about what choices there are doing a curriculum approval process, making sure that those curricular materials are aligned with expectations for early literacy, these kind of standards that we want to see, and then supporting folks to actually use them. We can talk all we want to do about kind of, you know, having great curriculum, but as from our lengthy five data, if we know that 60% of family child care is not using any curriculum,

[03:14:29] it doesn't matter if you have a whole bunch of approved curriculum, right? The big lift right there is supporting those incredible educators to use those materials and so by having this framework and this expectation that if you take a public dollar we are going to work with you support your leaders support your educators to be a part of this system and then thinking about how we align those individualized supports it really provides the pathway into every single infant toddler preschool mixed-age classroom across all these settings that take public dollars to make sure that we are supporting our educators to do

[03:15:04] this work and we too fund a lot of our direct professional development for child care it doesn't have the school division to provide that so we provide an extensive amount of professional development for child care and for our family day homes and we're constantly thinking about how we align that to these new expectations and how we're through lengthy five measuring and of how kids are growing affiliated down to the classroom level and these various elements so just wanted to kind of connect those dots and that we feel that this effort is very well aligned with delegate coiners efforts and that we are

[03:15:43] committed to working with our k-12 counterparts as well as with special education to make sure that we're bringing early childhood along as we're supporting these efforts in k3 and then this is just if you wanted to get into more of the detail these are the kind of in our language the early childhood language, how we think about language, phonological awareness, print knowledge, decoding, and early writing, right?

[03:16:07] And so it looks slightly different, but you'll notice the same core things that we heard nationally are important when you think about providing a good foundation for early literacy. And then this is just a couple of more key findings in terms of, and again, we'll talk more next month about what we're expecting for all 9,000 of our publicly funded classrooms, but noting that we don't while we do evaluate kids we absolutely refuse to put any high-stakes testing for young children that would be completely inappropriate we instead as you'll remember we look at these teacher-child interactions but there is extensive evidence that shows that in classrooms

[03:16:46] where they have high quality teacher-child interactions children do learn more including in the area of really early literacy and I say this because i think this is really important we never want to have in the commonwealth a situation where we're inadvertently trying to roll back second grade type literacy instruction onto two-year-olds it will not work right because the developmental age of the children young children learn in the context of warm and responsive relationships they learn through play if you tried to get a bunch of two-year-olds to sit there and you were to do sort of explicit phonics instruction you would probably not work, right?

[03:17:24] It doesn't mean that we're not thinking about phonics, but we have to do it differently. Use the evidence basis, use tools that we know have a positive effect on positive outcomes, and figure out how we ensure a seamless trajectory from early childhood through early elementary, but do it in a way that's age appropriate for the children that we're serving.

[03:17:47] And then lastly, this is just, again, letting you know that we are well underway, and we'll talk more about this next month, to support the use of high quality curriculum across all of our early childhood settings, including a new development, which is an open educational resource that will be available for our programs that cannot otherwise afford curriculum.

[03:18:07] So thinking about how in K-12 we'll have a review process as called forth by the law to make sure that we've got alignment. You can rest assured that we're doing that same work in early childhood to make sure there's alignment and noting that one of the biggest gaps we'll have to solve for is folks that are not using anything we've thought about that and we'll be partnering with an institution of higher education university of virginia to make sure that there's a resource it will always be a choice right similar to kind of k-12 in terms of making sure that programs or divisions can choose the curriculum choose the instructional materials but seeing our role as a state education agency to make sure that we have a thorough vetting process

[03:18:47] And again, for those programs that need additional support, making it free or low cost and supporting them to be able to use it over a multi-year time period. With that, I will turn it back to my K-12 colleagues.

[03:19:06] The next portion of the presentation will be to just share some initiatives and literacy supports around reading in the Commonwealth as far as initiatives go and reading professionals. The first one being the Early Intervention Reading Initiative. There's a full timeline of the Early Intervention Reading Initiative in your report, beginning on page 16, but just to highlight a few of the points pertaining to that.

[03:19:32] This began in 1997 through the Virginia Acts of Assembly to reduce the number of kindergarten and first graders who were showing reading problems through early diagnosis and intervention. And then in the year 2000, to expand the number of students that this would cover, and that That was also the year that the Virginia Department of Education began to partner with the University of Virginia to be able to provide the state-provided PALS screener, the Phonological Awareness Literacy Screener.

[03:20:00] Across the years, there has been some evolution to expand funding, expand the grade levels that were covered under the Early Intervention Reading Initiative. And then last year in 2021, House Bill 1865 began to incorporate some of these science-based practices into the early intervention reading initiative by adding that these interventions had to be explicit systematic and grounded in the science of reading and then we all are here today to talk about what happened in 2022 i will let colleen share a little bit more about literacy

[03:20:31] professionals and the people supporting this work okay so um and just to give some context as a recent reading specialist and instructional leaders in the field i will say that we know the value of what these literacy professionals bring to the table in terms of supports for our students so what I'm going to talk about briefly is just the context of what we currently have as endorsements for in Virginia and then just kind of clarify the difference between reading specialist and literacy

[03:21:11] coaches and what national research kind of how they kind of define it but also I do want to say that in our report we also reference mississippi's uh criteria that they developed it really is very solid and um there are links there so that you can reference that to see how it was kind of developed at their uh in their state as well so as you can see here currently in virginia the certification and endorsement uh as a reading specialist requires a completion of a master's program or if a master's program has already been completed then specific coursework in uh

[03:21:50] at a graduate level is required and that in culminating in a certificate there is not currently an endorsement for literacy coaching in virginia at this time so just for clarity although um so some roles overlap and the responsibilities overlap but there are specific and meaningful distinctions among the reading and literacy specialist the literacy and the literacy coach uh the main distinction and i think dr wright did a very you know succinct job of explaining this but being that the specialists reading specialists work directly with students um and coaches work with the teachers is more of how those definitions are

[03:22:29] are defined um on a national how they're panned out through through the nation uh and so this distinction though does support that necessary coursework and reading development um that would would be required for both of those roles. And so, you know, research has clarified that by determining which will best assist schools and district leaders to determine which roles are needed in specific schools. So if you see there some of the links that we have for you in our report, they kind of go back and discuss. It's very much at the moment based

[03:23:08] on what what a school needs is it more of a program level meaning looking at what we can do at the bigger picture or what do we do for our students who are needing our most interventions and so reading specialists currently predominantly work with students who are experiencing difficulties with reading and writing and they might provide some resources and ideas about assessment and instruction they might model lessons they might solve problems with teachers or facilitate group discussions response to intervention initiatives has had a great influence on the ways that the reading and literacy specialists support

[03:23:48] teachers and writers readers and writers experiencing difficulty at the early at the early level and so then the role of literacy coaching is to work with teachers and to facilitate improvement at the school level like we talked about through program development but it isn't uncommon for literacy coaches to work with individual teachers to improve those classroom instructions and their responsibilities might also include serving as a resource to teachers or leading teachers through observation feedback cycles and things of that nature so we just wanted to provide you with some of that context regarding the

[03:24:25] two predominant roles that support literacy instruction and again there are some great resources that we've embedded in the in our report and I'm going to turn it back over to Jill I believe I just wanted to take a quick high-level overview of some data that's available in at the end of your report and also in this presentation but just kind of give you an idea of where we are looking at PALS data and our SOL data so this is data that is brought to us

[03:25:02] from the PALS office and it is available from their report examining the Impact of COVID-19 on the Identification of At-Risk Students Fall 2021 Literacy Screening Findings. And so you can actually download this report and, you know, get into many more details.

[03:25:19] And if we had our PALS colleagues with us today, they could certainly provide additional details as well. But just to give you some key findings, their key takeaways that the researchers at UVA

shared with us key takeaway number one is that pals data from spring 2021 show that significantly more students ended the school year at high risk for reading difficulties as compared with spring 2019 key takeaway number two is that when the literacy data are examined by subgroup example

[03:25:53] demographic variables economic status there are indications that students who are black hispanic economically disadvantaged and language learners were disproportionately identified at being high risk for reading difficulties the at-risk proportions within these subgroups were higher than the statewide rate across k2 historically on pal screenings a large proportion of students with disabilities also have an elevated risk for reading difficulties the 2021 spring data suggest that a large number of students with disabilities are at risk for reading difficulties.

[03:26:33] And key takeaway number three, the remote administration option for PALS was an important tool for creating visibility of the early reading risk of all students enrolled in public school, and particularly for Asian, Black, Hispanic, and English language students. Overall, 29% of kindergarten assessments, 35% of first grade assessments, and 37% of second grade assessments were administered remotely. And then just to give you some more context, this is kind of showing

[03:27:12] you where it's broken down. The first one was just kind of a general overview, and then this is breaking it down by grade level. So if you want to kind of see that with our subgroups kind of pulled out for you. And then this is just another way to look at it. But the culminating conversation is kind of around the data and that it indicates that many more students and a higher proportion of students ended the 2020-2021 school year at a higher risk for reading difficulties

[03:27:44] as compared with students in pre-COVID 2019. Now switching over to our standards of learning reading assessments and i do have some colleagues here from the assessment office if they would like to add anything uh but just kind of wanted to show you this is a very broad overview this is a decade a decade of sol student performance here and it highlights the important dates of the last 10 years what you can see here is um in 2010 um well what you see here is for the 2012 2013 school year that

[03:28:21] That first yellow arrow shows when the 2010 standards of learning were assessed for the first time and when we added technology enhanced items for the first time. So those kind of interactive assessment items were added there.

[03:28:38] In switching back and forth between Google Slides and PowerPoint and Google Slides, our next arrow moved over, it jumped over a little bit, but that second arrow really should be on the 2016-2017 year where computer adaptive testing was introduced for the first time in grades three through five and then as you can see we have a year that is skipped because there was no end um end of year assessment in the 2019-2020 school year but the 2017 standards were assessed for the first time in this last year in 2020-2021 but it is important to note that it was

[03:29:16] It was a very limited population that participated in the assessment last spring. So in all reality, the results of this year's 21-22 SOL assessments will really provide us with the most accurate baseline information to look at assessment moving forward.

[03:29:35] And if you go to the next slide, you'll see here we did lump six through eight and end of course. So you can see all of secondary there. And you can see when technology enhanced items were addressed and then when computer adaptive testing was also included.

[03:29:51] It was later. So computer adaptive testing was used for the first time in grade eight in fall of 2017 and then for grades six and seven of spring of 2018. So just to kind of show you some data over time.

[03:30:06] And this is if we were looking at K-12, well really three through end of course. we're looking by student group as to when the different standards were assessed and what our assessment data looks like and then looking at our 2019 NAEP data I know you've all seen this before but please know when we're looking at our grade 4 and grade 8 proficiency proficiency on these tests is defined as solid academic performance over challenging subject matter including

[03:30:41] subject matter knowledge, application of such knowledge to real-world situations, and analytical skills appropriate to the subject matter. And while we remain above the national average, we do realize we have some work to do. And you can see that here both in grade four and in grade eight. So we do want to talk and just kind of switch over to some ongoing supports and what we have done since the 2019 NAEP scores came out, as that was kind of a very big eye-opener for Virginia. And I do know that in your reports, we actually have really fun timelines included. The font shows up so small

[03:31:21] here that we didn't include them in this presentation, and Google Slides only lets you have six events, and we've certainly done more than that, so we wanted to make sure that we highlighted these here. So, oops, excuse me, sorry about that. So, thinking about the NAEP scores coming out we did receive that information and virginia was one of the 17 states that saw declines in performance in fourth grade reading and one of 31 states to see declines in grade eight and so we jumped into action to be honest in october of 2019 a seven page superintendent's memo was

[03:31:58] released from the department that shared with divisions information and resources to support and align work with the 2017 English Standards of Learning. We also hosted a series of SOL conferences across the state that featured K-2 sessions for the first time.

[03:32:19] Elementary school teachers have always been invited to professional development that is offered by the State Department. However, when you consider substitutes and people missing work and all of that, it was quite typical that our elementary school principals often sent their grades three through five teachers because a lot of the work was aligned with assessment however we brought out and highlighted those k2 sessions for the first time we brought in the PALS office from UVA to work with teachers and show them how to access the reports and how those reports could inform instruction and provide them with some eye-opening

[03:32:57] information and material that could support their classroom instruction we We also partnered with VCU and the University of Richmond to provide K2, just professional development and instruction on K2 reading and writing and what that looks like in the classroom.

[03:33:14] In January 2020, right before everything kind of changed in Virginia, we did attend CCSSO's National Summit on Literacy, where we heard from many national level experts about different levers that state departments could take and actionable steps that we could bring back to Virginia to try to influence this work around early literacy. As a result of that work, we immediately kind of kicked it into high gear and hosted a comprehensive literacy webinar series where in the months of January and February, we hosted 22 webinars covering 11 topics where we

[03:33:53] worked and collaborated with institutes of higher education school divisions the office of assessment special education english language or instruction all around different supports for literacy

instruction to provide that information to the field then in uh esteemed fashion our agency leadership decided to host a literacy summit for virginia and we gathered in charlottesville in february of 2020 where we brought in again national experts we brought in uva to talk about

[03:34:28] early literacy we brought in members of the department of different offices within assessments english language learner instruction special education early childhood just to provide direct professional development and conversation around early literacy with division superintendents or the designees that they sent in the summer of 2020 in the middle of the pandemic we did work with assessment to collaborate as a state and provide feedback to nape on the new nape reading

[03:35:05] framework that will kind of look at assessment moving forward so that virginia could align its practices and provide that public comment but also have a strong idea of how nape is moving forward and then in fall of 2020 we hosted a comprehensive literacy webinar series again another one and then an assessment supports webinar series where we worked with a variety of different partners to kind of address what learning might look like if we're talking about best literacy practices for learning in place or for hybrid instruction and how we could maximize literacy instruction

[03:35:42] no matter what kind of situation we found ourselves in and then we collaborated with the assessment office to offer a series of supports for supporting instruction leading up to that new sol assessment because the assessment would cover the 2017 standards for the first time and we wanted to make sure that our teachers were prepared and that the instruction was matching and was aligned with our work in spring of 2021 we worked to create what we call professional development on demand we have a page created where we have put together basically

[03:36:17] bundles and english professional development packages for school divisions to use we were really trying to support school divisions in this effort as they were exploring what they could do maybe instead of a faculty meeting maybe instead of a plc where they could gather and just kind of converse and talk about different topics so if you were to check out that english professional development page you would find over 20 topics where we have webinars instructional plans powerpoints research whatever the case may be around different topics whether that's how to use pals reports early literacy hybrid instruction interdisciplinary literacy performance assessments

[03:36:56] for high schools whatever the case may be we have those bundles there to support conversations and networking around the state and then because we like to challenge ourselves even more in august we hosted eight nights in a row of English SOL conferences that were K-12, where we featured specific K-2 events, again, bringing in experts to talk about phonological and phonemic awareness, having school divisions where they were seeing gains and improved instruction come in and share what they were doing. We hosted everything from kindergarten all the way through 12th grade for

[03:37:36] those eight nights. And then we hosted an inaugural family literacy night where we really tested the Virginia Department of Education's YouTube capabilities. And we streamed three different channels of three different channels going on, hosting nine different sessions that parents could kind of join in via Zoom or just going to the department's YouTube. And we worked with our early literacy our department of early literacy we worked with our friends and student assessment we collaborated with the virginia state literacy association the virginia association for

[03:38:13] teachers of english our dyslexia specialist here at the department different colleagues from around the state and just tried to connect and bring in parents to converse around literacy and what they

they could be doing at home to support their youngest learners.

[03:38:30] And then in the fall of 2021, as we started to implement those student growth measures, we did collaborate with the assessment staff again to explore how you might utilize the data that you are obtaining from those student growth measures, but also anecdotal data, formative data, summative data, whatever data you have at your disposal within your school to maximize literacy instruction this year and how you might support your students moving forward with whatever data you have.

[03:39:00] And then, you know, obviously there's a lot around this bill, there's a lot of work to be done. We're really excited about the work, but you know, we are going to work, you know, to continue our professional development, to bring in more people in whatever way that we can.

[03:39:15] We will be supporting the PALS 2.0, which Carmen is also going to be talking about kind of what that looks like, you have a quick overview of that and then while i do know that micro credentialing is certainly part of the bill we have also been exploring some additional micro credentialing separate of this but if it can marry together that would be amazing but we wanted to look at not only early literacy micro credentialing but what does that look like for adolescent literacy and what does that look like for literacy leaders how are we literacy leaders whether that's for literacy coaches reading specialists, building leaders, administrators, whatever the case may be, if we can work

[03:39:52] out that funding and see if we can provide some additional micro-credentialing and professional development for teachers. And I'm just going to have Carmen come up really quickly and just kind of give you the big revision to PALS so that you understand how the new state, the revisions to the state screener will align with all of this work as well.

[03:40:13] This will be a very high-level overview of the revisions that are happening with the phonological awareness literacy screener. This is the state provided early literacy screener. They are undergoing currently, as we speak, some bigger visions to the screener.

[03:40:30] And some of those are to bring PALS pre-K, PALS kindergarten, and PALS one through three into alignment with the research of the science of reading. So they're adding tasks that align with the science and evidence-based research that we've been talking about today, such as adding language-based tasks, as we discussed, revising some of their existing tasks, and including a revision to their PALS espanol assessment.

[03:40:53] So that will be available for students perhaps in those dual language classrooms where we want to assess their literacy abilities in English, also in Spanish. They are expanding downward to three-year-olds to really provide a vertical picture of what a student's literacy development looks like from when they're three all the way up until second and third grade.

[03:41:14] and then adding vertical alignment across the board from those three-year-olds all the way up until possibly the beginning of third grade as it currently stands the the pals pre-k pals k and pals one through three some of those tasks are very different and it is hard to see some of that vertical alignment so this will allow that to happen to see growth over time piloting for this began in fall 2021 and it is expected to be full implementation in classrooms by fall 2024.

[03:41:44] So this is just kind of a model to show what that vertical development looks like and how we can look at students across time. So in three- and four-year-olds, looking at those print concepts, alphabet knowledge, phonological awareness, rapid, automatized naming, emergent writing, oral language.

[03:42:01] And then in kindergarten, looking at adding that decoding and encoding piece, vocabulary and language, and same with Powell's first through third grade. So that is a high-level overview, and if you have any additional questions, we can certainly reach out to our colleagues at the PALS office to get more information on that.

[03:42:18] So I believe Jill is going to close us out. Yeah, so we just want to thank you guys for the opportunity to speak with you. Maybe I went too far. As teachers of literacy and literature, you know that we love a good theme and a good metaphor and a good symbol.

[03:42:33] So much like the reading rope, where all the components work together to make skilled and create skilled readers, we see each of our roles here as essential to strengthening literacy here in the Commonwealth. So we just want to thank you for your time. We know this is a very expansive topic and your heads are probably swimming, but we will welcome any questions you may have at this time. Okay. Well, thank you for the comprehensive presentation. Are there any questions at this time? Yes, Dr. Mann.

[03:43:08] Thank you for the presentation. I had a quick question, just curious about what the current capacity of reading specialists are across the Commonwealth. You know, there's a lot of data that's been presented around children and i think i heard in one of the earlier presentations that it is currently discretionary for districts to actually engage reading specialists and i am really curious to just appreciate what we know about the current capacity of reading specialists given the import of their role in this effort absolutely and the data that we included in your

[03:43:45] report that talks about the total number of reading specialists here in Virginia this is based on what's available in I've house so we don't know if there is another way that these reading specialists could be coded which might change the numbers that are here but if you were to look at this there are just you know several hundred within our eight superintendents regions that are included as being utilized as reading specialists in their schools now that does not mean that we don't have more licensed people who are being uh are serving

[03:44:19] their community in another way yeah i was curious about the license number just because of the ratio of you know one to what was it 550 or something like that i can remember the number but yeah um i can certainly look into that i can pull that from teacher licensure thank you yeah thank you mr president and thank you for the presentation um i appreciate it so much um just just a little bit uh not necessarily a question just a little bit of what uh delegate coiner called cleanup and and that is with regard to the word or the term specialist reading specialist and i love how

[03:44:59] you clarified at the national level this is the difference between a specialist and a coach in virginia the term reading specialist in the literacy act really is what you defined as a coach so it is a person within a school who has a leadership position kind of a master reading teacher who works primarily with data and with teachers on professional development so there's no bit of professional development that's kind of sit and get and then go back to your classroom and hope you do it the best that that you can or or incorporate what you learned

[03:45:32] um the reading specialist by virtue of the virginia literacy act is that coach who who continues to support teachers inside of the school um and and the goal is to make sure that all elementary teachers are reading specialists and are equipped with the skills that they need to provide appropriate interventions for all tiers of readers um and and then and and really nationally we throw around terms um facilitator

coach and specialist and we use them interchangeably and um yet at at the state and the national level there are distinctions among them so i just wanted

[03:46:12] to to put that out and then um you know just on on behalf of vdoe we're still unpacking the legislation frankly um you know nothing is done until it's done and one month ago we were reporting really great news about the progress of the literacy act and today it's better news because it's passed um for for all intents and purposes but i just want you to know that as we reprioritize our agency, frankly, and our work around the Literacy Act.

[03:46:43] You'll be hearing us talk more and more about how we've streamlined these efforts with the Literacy Act and how we've streamlined a lot of the work in the agency that may not seem like it's literacy, per se, but is indirectly related, and how we've reprioritized that to the Literacy Act in our work at the SEA. So I just wanted to lay those two things out there and thank you, you did a great job. Can I ask one quick question which may show my lack of understanding of some

[03:47:18] of this area, okay? As we implement the terms of the Virginia Literacy Act, what changes in the classroom and what percentage of classrooms do we expect to see change in? In other words, I know we're moving to science-based theories of reading right uh certainly a percentage of our teachers are already doing this what do we expect to see change and i mean it's not a you know it really is a serious question you know because if you look at the mississippi experience uh you know

[03:47:57] eight years in they're still climbing right so we're talking about a fairly gradual generational shift here in generational in terms of school kids what do we expect to see anybody want to take this or should I just put it for the next meeting no no no you're good I think right now and I think as you mentioned Juliet's research kind of really explored what was currently in use in k-12 classroom k2 classrooms in Virginia and just the wide variety of different teaching tools and teaching styles that are being used currently right now the Virginia

[03:48:35] Department of Education when we say do our textbook review process we are looking at alignment to standards of learning and it sounds like if I am fully understanding the Virginia Literacy Act correctly that we will be providing lists of approved curriculum that would really help support and to determine how the material is taught in the classroom whereas currently we just look at how things align to standards so it sounds to me like if we move with some of this approved curriculum that would really kind of lock down and support what teachers need in the classrooms to kind of bring in these

[03:49:15] evidence-based practices I think you probably saw in Juliet's research that a lot of people are just kind of pulling things from all over that they think will be engaging to their students in the classroom so this will be a lot more intentional and deliberate and you know evidence-based to be explicit and systematic so we should see a difference of a right we can approve and unlike mississippi where it appears that the board of ed actually appoints the county superintendents the local ones we don't have that kind of control what i thought we were also doing was sort of mandating teacher familiarity

[03:49:50] with the science-based breeding techniques yes that'll take a little bit of time right it'll be required but it'll take some time uh and maybe francisco you might be the one to answer this since you've done this in Arlington. I mean, what changes do you actually see in the classroom?

[03:50:07] And, you know, have you noticed in the K-2 cohort, you know, any improvements? I mean, by the way, I don't want the question to be taken as a negative. I believe in what we're doing here, but I think

it's important to lay out expectations and to have an understanding of the logic of what we're doing and how it translates from broader state policy down into what a classroom teacher teaches her kids or his kids.

[03:50:34] we have seen a huge shift in all of our classrooms because in our school system previously we were using um lucy caulkins as the full language approach materials and we've shifted to using foundations 95 is our curriculum provided training to all of our teachers so all of our classrooms have shifted 100 in terms of the interactions with teachers and students and we've already seen looking at the data some great in arlington we're using pals and we're also at the pilot of the 2.0 or we're also seek a waiver so we're also using dibbles so from our dibbles data we are seeing some great gains from all the different students so it's an immediate shift but it's a long-term

[03:51:11] learning for how teachers begin to understand and impact all the various elements but you will see an immediate shift in all classrooms okay and what do you think the impact will be on the nape scores well the nape scores again i would defer to you in terms of the alignment of the new framework that they're doing but if they are aligned in the same way that they need to be and i'm also pleases that pals 2.0 is being realigned in that way if they are aligned in that way then i believe you'll see much a lot of great games there as well but the challenge and frankly you know many of you know that i when i was in fairfax we i was the chief academic officer there we moved to not use pals as the foundation and it's the one school system that's not using it

[03:51:49] because oftentimes the assessments aren't aligned with what we're asking and also in many cases aren't capturing all the students needs and what we saw there from the data many years ago i think it was about six years ago now it's been a while i know it was superintendent staples that was here at the time we began to notice that the instruction and what's happening there was not aligned with some of the assessments so i'm glad to see and i was happy to see all the work that's being done to align those assessments so that we're properly able to have a formative view of what's happening for students and i do think that we will probably see that when as soon as pals 2.0 is implemented in 2024 since the tasks will align with those evidence-based

[03:52:29] practices we will see how students are performing on that screener at the end of the year over time to see where they started and where they ended based on that classroom instruction and then the the interventions and supplemental instruction that occurred with the supports that we have in place between the beginning of the year and the end of the year so I do think we would see that sooner rather than later as soon as we have that pals revision complete do - Do we expect to see any pockets of resistance?

[03:52:59] - I don't know which one's on, there are. - I just wanted to, oh sorry. - No, go ahead, then I'll ask it again. - I was just following up to what Jill was sharing. We, as Superintendent Bailo mentioned, we are still unpacking the legislation here as an agency ourselves, but I believe the changes that you're asking about, you'll see changes at the state level, at the division level, and at the classroom level, so I could speak a little bit more to maybe some possible changes might see if you were walking into a classroom at the division level you would see some curricular changes but in a classroom you might see whereas phonics instruction was used potentially as a

[03:53:35] i see they are struggling on this i will do some phonics on it you'll see it more as a proactive approach to phonics of following that scope and sequence being explicit with what we're learning and being proactive about the phonics instruction that they're using you would see changes in the prompts

that teachers are giving when students encounter unknown words whereas sometimes you may see a teacher prompt a student to look at the picture to get some context on what that that word might be you will see teachers prompting students to really decode that word as a follow up to their phonics instruction while we know context is hugely important in figuring out the

[03:54:11] meaning of words it is not as important to figure out to read the word itself you will see exposure to rich literature and i believe any anybody who teaches literacy or touches literacy would not argue that rich literature is a huge piece of the puzzle but you will see rich literature being used specifically for building that listening comprehension and building that vocabulary and building that background and all of the communities and divisions across the commonwealth are in their own journey in this process but those are just a few of the classroom changes that um that you might see i appreciate that a lot uh and then the follow-up

[03:54:46] question was, do we expect, you know, any resistance? You know, one of the things that we hear in some of the MOU jurisdictions is sort of that tension between teaching freedom and uniformity of teaching, right? It's, you know, the comment comes over and over again, teachers tend, I shouldn't say tend to, there are reports that some teachers resist the uniformity that's needed to align teaching to the standards, right? And in particular, my experience has been talking to the people in the mou jurisdictions do we expect any pushback here i guess the reason i

[03:55:24] ask is if this is also obvious why aren't people doing it well one thing i think is important is people have not been trained and in this way and so when people come into their their people are more comfortable as you begin to provide them additional training and so we began in our journey training all of our principals assistant principals with the letters training so that the leaders understood the background and had the confidence and knowing exactly what the research was about then as you work with teachers you begin to help them understand and provide them that training that's when you begin to see less resistance people aren't quote-unquote resistant because at the end of the day teachers want students to be successful we've seen a couple of teachers who've

[03:56:03] been concerned about the shift and were very comfortable with their previous approach to how they set up their classroom but as they've begun to see the success of their students i've spoken with many of them individually as i visit their classrooms like wow this is amazing to see and And they shared with me, I wasn't really excited about this.

[03:56:19] I didn't want to do this. But I know we're moving this direction. But seeing their students be successful. So I think it's important to note that it's a whole approach. And we heard coming from our university partners, coming from our leadership development teachers. If you just say this is the movement and you have to do it, then, of course, you're going to have a lot more resistance.

[03:56:37] But when you build the foundation, you build the why, you build the skills, and you build the foundation for everyone to understand, I think you're going to see less resistance then. And we've seen this resistance. - I appreciate the background. It informs, frankly, the work that we will do as it comes to implementing this, how much we have to message versus, you know, how much we have to mandate versus just, it helps me understand where we're gonna be as we work through this process as a board.

[03:57:05] - And I will just add that after our eight evenings of SOL conferences, the feedback that we got from teachers, especially our K2 teachers was just, it was phenomenal. They were so encouraged and they felt like had something that was specific to their needs and it would meet the needs of their students.

[03:57:22] So to feel included and to feel part of a process and to feel like they had something that was specific to them as we looked at phonological awareness and what the science of reading and best practices looked like. And that was just, you know, two, three-hour evenings of K2 specific high-level instructional practices.

[03:57:41] They really felt like they had something they could latch onto and people that they could reach out to for additional support moving forward. Great, thank you so much. Two other very important things is making sure that they have the right resources and ensure, because that's, if you're a teacher and you're asked to do something that's very different than what you've done and you've not been trained in it, and then you don't have the resources, that I think is where there's a lot of, I wouldn't call it resistance, but a lot of concern and frustration I would call.

[03:58:07] Number two, as I said already, but I want to double down again, the assessments. When we're not assessing in the same way and we don't have screeners that are being intentional about the same way we're asking teachers to make the shift that is very frustrating and so from a teacher's perspective to be asked to do something different and not have the resources and be assessed in a different way without the professional development and training coming in from your university preparation program not having been taught this way that's where there's frustration not resistance because at the end of the day they want their students to be successful but we have to be mindful of all those key components to set them up for success if we we want them to help their students be successful.

[03:58:45] - Okay, Ms. Holton. - President Gecker. - Yes, ma'am. - If I could add to Dr. Duran and what he is talking about there too, on the boots on the ground perspective, what you're going to see are elementary school reading classrooms that are focusing on the individuality of the students and what their current reading levels are and their intensive needs.

[03:59:08] So as you see a reading block of 90 minutes, possibly 120 minutes incorporating all five aspects of literacy you're going to see more need especially in the economically disadvantaged areas a need for for not only more resources for the teachers but also a little bit more staffing because you could have this currently right now I have a classroom with five reading levels in it and that that one teacher has three different folks that come in and help her to meet the individual needs of those

[03:59:43] students who run a Gambit from a pre-A level, which is before kindergarten, up to a third grade reading level. So you're going to need resources, you're going to need staffing, and you're going to need the ability of the teachers to understand that once they understand that they're individualizing the instruction to help these children achieve the best reading abilities that they can achieve, going to catch on and the teacher is going to want to do this more it is going to take a lot of training it's going to take a mindset of okay I've got this

[04:00:20] group of students on this level and a set of lesson plans this group of students in the same classroom with this level with a set of lesson plans and so you could actually have like this one teacher could have five preps within one

[04:00:34] 90-minute block because as the groups move around from a teacher-directed activity, whole group phonics, teacher-directed individualized groups, getting individualized attention, it's a thing of beauty and these teachers work so very hard and in our area we're doing this now and I'm sure we're going to get better at it as it comes down from the department and I'm very proud of the way the teachers are

handling this and moving forward and understanding that It's no longer about, you know, what the pacing guide says.

[04:01:09] It's about individualization and differentiating their lessons to meet the needs of all of the learners in the classroom, even exceeding the grade level and those high achievers that desperately need that attention too. So before I stop, I'd like to say, ladies, thank you very much for your comprehensive overview of everything that we're doing for literacy in the state of Virginia.

[04:01:32] You're doing a fantastic job, and everything that you're saying is echoed in all the practices that you are sending out to the regions and delivered to the districts to be in the classroom. So thank you very much. I take a lot of pride in everything that you're doing, if I could possibly do that, and take that from you and be very proud of everything that you're doing.

[04:01:55] So thank you. Yes, Ms. Holton, I was going to just say thank you. That was great, Pam. But go ahead. Thank you. - So I have actually a question for Ms. Couric, I think for Ms. Couric and then a question for Ms. Conway.

[04:02:12] Ms. Couric, if I understand correctly, one thing we don't need to align is, I think our standards of learning and maybe the curriculum framework are already aligned. I'm not hearing you say that we need to do work to align those.

[04:02:28] And I'm seeing Superintendent Baylow, I think nodding affirmatively, good, good. So then there is a question, do our standards of learning assessments align? hear you saying we've got to do work to align the PALS assessment. I'm guessing the third grade, since third grade is our first SOL assessment, that maybe there's not a lot of work to align that either, but if so, we need to know that. But then I'm hearing that the major gap then is not our standards, it's not our curriculum framework, it's the uptake in the classroom. And that's a matter of curriculum, resources, and training, professional training.

[04:03:08] On those three, there's got to be, and we're hearing that there are local, there's local uptake, a good practice, right? So there's got to be either district-wide or school-wide or individual classroom examples of people who are doing it right already, because there's nothing really brand new, brand new about any of this.

[04:03:31] So I guess my question is, have we looked for, have we assessed who's doing it right who's doing it not so right yet and if we haven't can we do that so that we can I mean found models found pilots is a huge motivator so if you can find classrooms or districts or schools that are doing it right and getting results and then you know I've done this in other reform areas if you can tell the folk you know well when I was doing foster care reform we used we had some districts that I won't name now because what you when I used to name them the

[04:04:08] rest of the state would groan because they were sick of hearing about how well so and so was doing but you know if you can find some models it would be really valuable but I'm I'm not hearing that we've figured out who's doing what yet so we don't yet I'm not hearing that we yet know who's doing it right and who's not yet doing it right yeah so that that I do mean that as a question am I right do we know and if not how do we find out to answer the first part of your question about yes sorry um the standards yes the standards do align with um the standards don't tell us how to teach they most necessarily tell us what to teach so um they are aligned in the in those practices

[04:04:48] and what we're kind of looking at is the approach to get that done um we began that process of looking at across the commonwealth at sol scores i believe in 20 fall of 2019 fall of 2019 um to really examine those divisions and those individual schools that showed growth on their standards of learning assessments from third grade all the way up until end of course i believe and had some interviews with those division leaders their reading specialist whoever was at the table and i believe our assessment office can also speak speak more to this probably

[04:05:25] and then combined all of that feedback and information that we got from those individual schools and hosted a webinar in collaboration with the office of student assessment on what those effective practices were that came out of those divisions and i believe as far as the early literacy piece goes that work started um with juliet's report last year to really examine what school divisions are using um out there and we hope to continue that work um i think as you were saying we're just kind of on the cusp of that through through this process and this legislation And anecdotally, Carmen and I were at an elementary school visiting where they were using these practices

[04:06:04] and seeing some real gains as our last day out and about before school shut down. That is where we spent our last day. So we were already exploring some of this, and then things got a little crazy and turned upside down, but we are certainly back on the prowl. So we'd love to hear more, as you find, anecdotally and or through analysis of all the different data we have that relates from PALS on up to early literacy.

[04:06:30] You know, find those, what's working and what's not working and come back and tell us so that we can help promote it. And then if I may ask my question to Ms. Conway, we heard from our Mississippi superintendent guest earlier that she's got 50% almost of her students coming into kindergarten having had some kind of high quality public pre-K experience, If I understood it correctly, and I know in Virginia we're pushing public-private options, the models, but what percentage, where are we on that?

[04:07:06] What's our comparable percentage, and how far do we have to go, and where are we on making progress on that? I should ask you, Ms. Holden, as I believe I presented these slides to this group last year, but no, it just became so much information today.

[04:07:23] and so right now when you look at three and four year olds we serve about a third of the kids who are kind of would be considered at need or sort of in need or at risk across the three and four year olds we serve more four-year-olds so I think we're roughly at if we have let's bring this fairly easy about 90,000 kindergartners 100,000 first graders we are closer to about 40,000 kids coming Having had a four-year-old experience so still four out of ten lower than the Mississippi are we on a path?

[04:08:02] Or is that still subject to what's going on in the general assembly on funding right now to being close to where missus? You know where we start out stronger than Mississippi on many things But I'm hearing you say we're starting out behind where Mississippi currently is in terms of hardly is yeah early childhood our

[04:08:19] experience of our kindergartner our students kindergarten readiness opportunities. Absolutely. We've worked closely with our new administration as well as the both houses both chambers in the general assembly. I will say that the early childhood sections of the budget right now are still being worked out but look promising in terms of really two things. One is growing enrollment based on parental demand which continues to grow as parents recognize similar to what Dr. Duran said for teachers, as parents realize the incredible experience that preschool can offer.

[04:08:55] We have had a full rebound from some of the pandemic-related drops in enrollment. I think, secondly, our language in the budget this year calls about -- really calls for cost-based, like setting the rates for early childhood based on the actual cost to operate for the Virginia Preschool Initiative, for mixed delivery, and for the child care subsidy program.

[04:09:18] really positions this board well to do is to say what are the health safety and learning right with a real emphasis on the learning here today expectations that we want to see for all publicly funded programs and how do we begin to make sure that we fund them to be successful I think we then have a real return on investment and actually delegate corner was chatting with me about this in the break right and we can go back to our legislature and said yes we're at you know 40% now but we can show you the evidence we know down to classroom level here's the curriculum use here's the growth and the three-year-olds here's the growth in the four-year-olds here's how that translates into vkrp and subsequent pals and sol

[04:09:58] results and so it became we hopefully will become a virtuous cycle of like let's continue to grow it in a way that it aligns with parent choice and parent demand but that ultimately gets to a place where more children have an experience that gives them every opportunity to be successful upon coming to school.

[04:10:17] Thank you. Thank you all. Thank you all very much. Okay.

[04:10:35] Development of new assessment item. Type for integration of reading and writing. Good afternoon, President Gecker, members of the board, and Superintendent Balo.

[04:10:59] I guess once again I stand between you and dinner. So I will try to do this as quickly as possible. While my topic is not very exciting sounding this afternoon, it is something that we are excited about and I'm particularly passionate about this work so you've heard a lot this afternoon about literacy and all of the supports that have been provided by the department in the last several years but it's also important that our statewide assessments even though they're used for accountability purposes also support good instruction to the extent that we

[04:11:38] can make them do that so what I'm going to talk with you about today is a new item type that we're developing that we are hoping will support that idea of literacy and it is a new item type that will integrate reading and writing and it will be part of the grade 5 grade 8 and end of course reading assessments the way it works is it will require students to provide a written response a short paper to a prompt but that prompt will be based on a passage that the students have read and so the idea here is really to try to integrate the idea

[04:12:16] of reading and writing you heard the idea of the the ropes in the presentations that Jill and others made so the idea here is to try to really support that idea of integration of reading and writing so you also heard a lot about the literacy plan that department staff put together summit that we had in the plan and that summit really focused on trying to ensure that students are exposed to grade-level instruction but also providing opportunities for them to write about what they have read and so the idea of this new assessment would be

[04:12:55] to support that so as it is right now our assessments don't really support the idea of integrating reading and writing our current reading assessments are passage based where students read a passage and answer some questions as you all know our grades three through eight reading assessments are computer

adaptive so the assessments really are customized for the students and of course high school assessment is not adaptive it is an assessment where students all get the same items but again they all of the reading assessments

[04:13:34] just have passages and then items that are either multiple choice or technology enhanced and really address the student's reading comprehension and then we have a separate writing assessment which we've we've had in place for quite some time currently we assess writing at grade 8 in high school the writing test has had two components for quite some time and they're given on separate days in the first one students encounter some draft text that has arrows in it and so the students are then respond to multiple choice or technology enhanced items

[04:14:12] where they're correcting those errors so it might be an error in grammar punctuation capitalization or maybe they need to revise the text that is in the that is in the passage and then the second component they actually are writing a short paper in response to to a prompt and the prompt really provides a context for them to write, and it could be an issue or a hypothetical situation.

[04:14:43] And then their response to that prompt receives two scores. One is on composing and written expression, and then the second one is on usage and mechanics. So as you can see with the two separate assessments, our current system is not really supporting the idea of integrating reading and writing.

[04:15:03] what we're finding at least anecdotally is that the class schedules often separate reading and writing instruction they might be 45 minutes for reading instruction 45 minutes for writing instruction but we're not seeing students write about what they've read to the extent we want them to we've also found over the last few years that we've heard quite a bit about writing instruction really focusing on those passages that have embedded arrows and students correcting those rather than having students actually write so we are concerned that our current writing assessment the way it's configured may

[04:15:43] actually be having some negative impact on writing instruction and then Carmen mentioned this a little bit but after the 2019 drop in the SOL reading scores and the concurrent to drop in the NAEP scores we did do interviews with with school staff, and Ms. Holt, and this is really what you were talking about. Whenever we have a situation like this, we always look for, so who is doing well despite the rest of the Commonwealth not doing so well? And so we did do extensive interviews with schools where

[04:16:22] they had either maintained their pass rates or actually increased them. And one of the things we heard repeatedly was that the integration of reading and writing instruction was really important and having students again write about what they were reading in class and so really those interviews suggested what we're looking at now that integration of reading and writing so really what we're trying to do is come up with a new item type where students will read a

[04:16:58] nonfiction passage we are basing that passage on either history or science content in the hopes that we can reinforce the importance of reading and writing across the curriculum and also improving students exposure to to nonfiction content the passage would then have three to six items that would be associated with it these would get at more of the reading comprehension idea but then there would be a prompt attached to it where students would be

[04:17:29] asked to respond in some way based on the passage. So the use of the history or the science content is really consistent with the 2026 NAEP framework. I think Colleen mentioned that we had

provided input on that framework. And one of the things the new NAEP framework will do is it will actually report separate sub-scales on comprehending history and comprehending science.

[04:18:01] So we feel like we are in good company to be focusing on those particular content areas. So this will be an additional item type that will be added to the reading assessment.

[04:18:17] The benefit is it would provide an idea of the student's writing skill without this additional test that we normally that we currently have with writing um and then i wanted to talk a little bit about how this might be used in grade five um you all are aware that currently we do not have a writing assessment in grade five up until from 1998 until 2014 we did have a grade five writing assessment but it is one of the assessments that was eliminated by action of the general assembly

[04:18:51] in 2014 um that legislation also required that school divisions administer some sort of a local assessment of writing at grade five and um this new item type that we're talking about could become an option for school divisions to use um as another means of this of a local assessment so instead of having to do a local assessment on writing proficiency at grade five you all might decide that you would allow them to use that the item type that would go with

[04:19:27] the grade 5 reading assessment instead as a way of meeting that requirement so that might be a possibility for grade 5 um again we always do desk reviews it sounds a little scary but after each year we do look at the local assessments that schools are using and when we last were able to do this in 2019 we found that really having to do these local assessments and score them locally is it is providing a strain on

[04:20:02] school divisions so we think that there might be some interest in using the integrated reading and writing component of the reading test instead of having to to do a local assessment and that would mean that school divisions that chose this option would no longer have to develop and monitor a balanced assessment plan like they normally do so again we've talked about it being a separate component it would be on a in a separate test session probably on a separate a different day we would

[04:20:37] continue to have a reading score as we do currently that would be used for federal accountability but we would also have a separate score it might be called the literacy score that would look at the integration of reading and writing and we would continue to use the rubric reviews for quite some time and then provide also information on how the students scored on that rubric in the book in the score report again the student would continue to receive a regular reading score they would have a performance level we would continue to

[04:21:14] use that for growth comparing that score to the fall and winter growth assessments and we did provide you with an example of of what this integrated item type might look like this particular one is based on an article that we found in the cyclopedia virginia website and it's it's the article is about the richmond bread riot um and it's in your hard copy um report it just it was too much to put on the slides and please do notice that this example has just a passage and a prompt

[04:21:52] it doesn't have any multiple choice or technology enhanced items that go with it but just to give you a summary the the article is about the richmond bread riot that occurred in 1863 at that time there had been such an influx of people into richmond that we'd reached a population of 100 000 it's hard to think about that being a large population but it was in 1863 and there was not sufficient food so the women of the city marched to the governor's mansion demanded to see the governor it's unclear what happened then whether he saw them and they were dissatisfied

[04:22:30] with his response or whether he refused to see them but the women then marched down to Chaco bottom into the warehouses and the grocery stores and began to actually steal the bread to feed their families so that that's sort of a context of what the passage is about and then this is the the prompt and it really is about you know current technology allows us to immediately share information but the time of the bread riot in the majority of the information we have about that

[04:23:06] occurrence was from first-person accounts so the prompt asked the student to analyze the the use of first-person accounts and talk about the pros and cons they can either use the information from the passage or they can use other experiences they have but I think you can see from this the the integration of reading and writing instead of just asking the student to write about a topic we're actually asking them to respond to a prompt that's connected to something that they have read so timeline we are developing these currently our

[04:23:45] plan is to have them reviewed by teacher committees this summer we have sample questions available for our school divisions to use this fall we would field testing next spring and then we'll be ready to implement in spring of 24. we're using cares act funds to do this and so that's why the the very aggressive timeline we will provide support collaborating with our friends and instruction i think you heard from the presentation that we do have a really strong partnership with instruction

[04:24:19] we're very blessed to have talented specialists both on the instruction side and also the assessment side who work very well together so they have been working diligently on preparing these new items and then of course we would provide support through webinars and other resources beginning in the summertime we talked about how the new item type might be used for grade five grade eight depending on how you all want to act it's possible that you could decide

[04:24:54] that you know we would be getting sufficient information on writing with this new item type integrated into the reading test and you might consider eliminating the grade 8 writing test a standalone test at some point and then for end of course this new item type and the new score might allow a different way of earning verified credits that would be a more complicated decision on your part but it is something that could happen um this integrated reading and writing

[04:25:29] item type is something we've actually been wanting to do for a very long time and i i i think it it would go a long way to supporting that integration of reading and writing and to hopefully support what we want to happen in the classroom so um mr gecker i did that very quickly but do you have are there any questions i thought you did great well you know i naturally speak sort of slowly so it is difficult to go that fast. I appreciate the clarity of it.

[04:26:06] Just one maybe closing comment. Thank you so much for the presentation. I just want to underscore that as nations are, excuse me, as nations, how about as states are thinking about ways to be innovative with their statewide assessments, Shelley is at the front leading a lot of those conversations. And Virginia, the simple truth is that Virginia is the most stable, valid, and reliable assessment in the nation, period. And so to think about these, you know, these small shifts, they look small, they're not small. And they make

[04:26:46] a difference in the way that we look at the data, at the way that we are able to glean information from the data. And I just thank you for your continued work. Thank you. Thank you very much. Any questions? I guess not.

[04:27:02] Shelly, let me ask you, would you prefer to be at the beginning next time or stay at the end? Because you get more questions earlier on. No, I think traditionally I usually close you out. At least I had a more exciting topic today than I sometimes do.

[04:27:17] There you go. Thank you so much for all you're doing. Appreciate it. Okay. I think that concludes, I think that's right, isn't it? Yeah, the business of the afternoon, you know, I know it's been a long day, and we still have the closed session to finish up, but I'll tell you, you know, I've been doing this, as we mentioned before, six years.

[04:27:44] Some of you have been involved with all this a lot longer than I have, but today was a pretty exciting day in terms of making forward progress, so I'm really happy that, you know, we had the opportunity to learn more about the literacy work. I'm happy that this is a direction that the Commonwealth is, you know, moving in.

[04:28:02] You know, we have seen over the years a lot of good ideas come through, right? There are always things that people want to do to tinker with the education system. But I don't know if we have seen any that have the same potential to move the needle significantly that this one does.

[04:28:21] That is the entire approach to literacy. And I got to tell you, it makes me pretty happy to be involved with something that I think is well worth the time that we're spending on it to make a difference in outcomes. You know, we've talked about this many times.

[04:28:38] The sole question, you know, I tend to ask is, you know, will it improve outcomes? And, you know, I wouldn't say finally because we've certainly done other things that, you know, have been had a positive impact. But in terms of bang for the buck, I think this one is it for us.

[04:28:54] And, you know, thanks to all of you for your support of this. Thanks to the staff. I know I ask questions that sometimes think, you know, may be taken negatively, but they're not meant that way. It's really an effort to understand what the downsides are so that we can plan for, you know, how we roll out what we're about to roll out.

[04:29:12] And so I appreciate the courtesy of staff and, you know, politely answering the questions instead of sort of storming off. So, you know, thanks to all of you. And as I said, you know, we learned from the Mississippi numbers that, you know, change may be slow in terms of how it filters out through a generation of school kids.

[04:29:33] But, you know, like I said, I believe in this course and I hope we that as a future boards stay this course and don't try to tinker with it, you know, too soon. You know, give it a chance to take root and do what it's supposed to do.

[04:29:50] So thanks to everybody. dr durant i just want to thank you and thank our state superintendent for having this work session today set up this way and the speakers you brought and the staff you brought and my four years on the board this was one of the best ones i've seen in terms of we've always had good presentations we've always had good information but this one really was i thought not only for the board but for the public and the community are watching a real good deep overview of where we are the good work we've done where our what our vision is moving forward and the exciting work ahead and i was really energized and inspired by this work session again i wanted to say this is

[04:30:27] one of the best i've been in four years so thank you um state superintendent thank you mr president and to the staff we're here to present this information the deep deep overview and the report was very very helpful for all of us who already in the work and those who are not in the work and grounded everyone to where we are and where we can go and where we are going to go i should say so So thank you.

[04:30:49] Yeah. Thank you. You could have said that before we adjourned. Yeah. We're not quite adjourned yet. Anybody else have any comments? If not, we will adjourn. And five minutes from now, the board will come back into session to finish up the executive session we didn't finish this morning.

[04:31:09] So thanks to everybody.